

THE TURNING OF THE BONES

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A Novel

ONE WAY EDITIONS

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The Republic of Madagascar, its institutions and its people are real, and are held here in affection. Nothing in these pages is intended as an allegation against any real individual, company or institution.

Technical descriptions are impressionistic and deliberately incomplete. They are written to be read, not followed.

FIRST EDITION

*For everyone who was told that the file had been lost, that
the boat had capsized, that the road at night is dangerous,
that these things are complicated, that nothing can be done.*

And for the ones who kept a copy anyway.

Ny fanahy no olona.

It is the spirit that makes the person.

— Malagasy proverb

A government can survive being hated. It can survive being feared. What it cannot survive is being read aloud.

— from the record of the Antsiranana Commission, Vol. IV

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PART ONE



THE LEDGER

Three Minutes Past Three

A man who has decided is not brave. He has simply stopped negotiating.

— Colonel Fanja Rasoanaivo, deposition, p. 402

At three minutes past three in the morning, Ravo Andrianasolo sat alone in a room cut into the granite of a headland at the top of the world's fourth-largest island and looked at a button he had spent eleven years and one billion four hundred million dollars earning the right to press.

The room was cold, because granite is always cold, and quiet in the particular way that only very expensive quiet can be. Two hundred and forty tonnes of ferro-cement and mountain lay between Ravo and the sky. The air came to him scrubbed and dry through a filter stack the size of a bus. Somewhere below his feet a seawater loop took the heat of nine hundred processors and gave it back to the Indian Ocean, one degree at a time, so that even the sea would not know what was being computed here.

On the desk: a cup of tea gone cold, a photograph in a cracked frame, and a keyboard.

On the wall of screens: a map of Madagascar rendered in fine gold lines, and over the map, forty-one small red dots, and beside the dots, forty-one names.

"Fanahy," Ravo said.

The house answered in his grandmother's voice, because eight years ago he had paid a studio in Réunion an obscene

amount of money to reconstruct it from four hours of cassette tape recorded at a family funeral in 1994.

Eto aho, zanako. I am here, my child.

“Read me the seventh entry.”

You have heard the seventh entry two thousand and nine times.

“Read it again.”

The house read it again.

Entry seven. Twelfth of March, two thousand and nine. Subject: RAKOTOBE, Andriamahefa Jean. Function: Deputy Controller of Manifests, Port of Toamasina, Quay Four. Category: obstruction, persistent. Method: road. Location: RN2, kilometre one hundred and eighty-six, descent of the Mandraka. Contractor: external. Settlement: eleven million ariary. Authorising initial: N.R. Status: closed.

There was a pause that the house did not need and had learned to take anyway.

Settlement in the currency of the day, the house added, was approximately four thousand one hundred United States dollars.

Ravo turned the photograph around and set it face-down on the desk, the way you turn a mirror in a house where someone has died.

Four thousand one hundred dollars. His father had cost less than the chair Ravo was sitting in. Less than the tea service. Less than one square metre of the blast glazing in the room upstairs, which was rated to stop a fourteen-point-five-millimetre round at three hundred metres and had cost, installed, six thousand two hundred dollars per square metre because the ship carrying it had been rerouted around a war.

He had known this for eleven weeks. He had built for eleven years. He had, if he was honest with himself — and he had made a discipline of being honest with himself, it was the only luxury that had never gotten cheaper — he had built this entire

absurd fortress for eleven years without knowing why, the way a body builds a scar over something it has not yet found.

Now he had found it.

“Fanahy. Status of One Way.”

All nine uplinks nominal. Ground stations Antsiranana, Toliara, Mahajanga, Sainte-Marie: nominal. Off-island relays: Mauritius, Nairobi, Reykjavík, Montevideo, Taipei, Tallinn, Toronto, Perth, Lagos: all nominal. Mirror count is forty-one thousand two hundred and sixteen and rising. Escrow at Geneva confirms the key fragment. Escrow at Wellington confirms the key fragment. Escrow at Reykjavík confirms the key fragment.

The dead man’s timer is armed. If your heart stops, or if you fail to sign in every seventy-two hours, or if this facility is destroyed, the archive publishes in eleven languages within four minutes. Nothing that is done to you can now un-publish it. Nothing that is done to me can now un-publish it. This was, if I may, the entire point.

“You may.”

Zanako. The house did the thing with the pause again. *Your grandmother would have asked whether you had eaten.*

“Tell her I ate.”

She would not have believed you.

Ravo laughed once, and the laugh went nowhere in the granite.



Here is what he was about to do, and it is worth being precise about it, because in the weeks that followed a great many people would describe it as an act of war, an act of terrorism, an act of foreign subversion, and — in one memorable communiqué that would later be read aloud in three languages before an international tribunal — “an assault upon the dignity of the Republic.”

He was about to upload a spreadsheet.

Two thousand seven hundred and four pages of PDF. Nine hundred and eleven scanned documents, including forty-two with fingerprint-matched signatures. Six hundred and eighty hours of audio, indexed and transcribed. A relational database of three hundred and ninety-two shell companies in eleven jurisdictions, traced end to end with the patient inhuman stubbornness of software that never needed to sleep or be paid or be frightened.

And the Ninth Column.

That was the part that made it a bomb rather than a scandal. A country can absorb theft. Every country absorbs theft; theft is weather. What no country absorbs is a column of a spreadsheet in which the theft has a price and the objection to the theft also has a price, and the two prices are in the same currency, in the same font, in the same file, four columns apart.

Forty-one names. Journalists, port inspectors, a hydrologist, two customs clerks, a nun who ran a rice cooperative in the south, a twenty-six-year-old blogger from Fianarantsoa, and a Deputy Controller of Manifests at Quay Four who had refused, for six years, to sign for containers that had never physically existed and whose contents had nevertheless been sold twice.

Ravo put his hand flat on the desk, feeling for the vibration of the sea through eleven metres of rock, which was the only thing in this building he had not designed and the only thing he trusted completely.

“Wake the Colonel,” he said. “Wake all of them. Tell them it is now.”



Colonel Fanja Rasoanaivo did not need to be woken. She had been awake for two hours and eleven minutes, standing on the upper terrace of Vatofotsy with a cup of coffee going cold in her left hand, because her right hand — the one with the two

missing fingers, taken from her in a wadi in Mali in 2013 by a piece of a Toyota — did not like to hold hot things any more.

She was fifty-one years old. She had been born in Ambanja among the ylang-ylang plantations, where the air in flowering season is so sweet it gives children headaches; she had left Madagascar at nineteen on a passport that was not, strictly, hers; and she had come back at forty-nine with a Legion pension, a French citizenship, a limp in wet weather, and a conviction, hardened in four countries, that the difference between a massacre and a bad afternoon is almost always logistics.

Below her, the headland fell three hundred metres to the Indian Ocean in three ragged steps, like a staircase built for something much larger than people. Vatofotsy — white stone — had been a French signal station in 1904, a coastal battery in 1942 when the British came for the bay, a leper hospital until 1961, and nothing at all for fifty-eight years, until a soft-spoken man with too much money had bought the whole peninsula, all four hundred and ten hectares of it, and registered it as a private nature reserve for the protection of a species of blue-eyed gecko that did, in fact, genuinely exist and did, in fact, genuinely live nowhere else on earth.

She had asked him once, early on, why he was building it.

He had said: *because my father used to say that in this country the only people who are safe are the people nobody can reach.*

She had said: *that is not a reason, that is a wound.*

He had said: *yes.*

She had taken the job anyway. It paid four hundred thousand euros a year and she had a daughter in medical school in Bordeaux.

The alert came into her ear as a single soft double-tone. Not the shriek of an intrusion. The other one. The one she had written herself, and had hoped, in the honest part of herself that she did not consult often, never to hear.

The principal has initiated, said the house, in the voice of a dead woman from Ambanja.

Fanja looked out at the black water where the lights of the fishing pirogues were beginning, tiny and orange, four kilometres out, men who had gone to sea at two in the morning because that was when the fish were and who had no idea, none at all, that the country they would come home to at nine would not be the same country.

“Well,” she said. “Mora mora.”

Slowly, slowly. It is what Malagasy say when the thing cannot be hurried.

Then she put down the coffee and went to war.



The upload took four minutes and nineteen seconds.

At three minutes past three in the morning, Ravo Andrianasolo was a wealthy eccentric, a returnee, a man of whom people in Antananarivo said *he came back, poor fellow, he'll be bored inside a year*.

At seven minutes past three, he was the most dangerous private citizen in the Indian Ocean.

He did not feel it. That is the thing nobody tells you. He felt the cold of the granite, and the sourness of the tea, and a small pathetic hunger, and — beneath everything, in the place where his father lived — a relief so enormous and so quiet that for a moment he could not breathe around it.

He turned the photograph face-up again.

A man in a short-sleeved shirt on a quay, squinting, holding a clipboard he had no idea was going to kill him, and behind him, a wall of containers painted with the names of companies that had never owned a single thing that could be touched.

“It’s done, Dada,” Ravo said. “It’s out. It’s all out.”

Somewhere above him the tethered aerostat they called the Kite turned slowly on its cable at three hundred metres, its in-

frared eye sweeping the black sea and the black mountains and the empty road, and found, as it had found every night for four years, nothing at all coming.

That would be the last night that was true.

What the File Said

We were not undone by an enemy. We were undone by a filing system.

— Testimony of an unnamed official, Antsiranana Commission

To understand why a government would attempt, over the following nineteen days, to kill one man with the enthusiasm normally reserved for a foreign invasion, you have to understand that the file was not about money.

Everyone said it was about money. The first wire reports said corruption; the first television panels said embezzlement; a French newspaper, with the reflexive condescension that had been the house style since 1896, said *une affaire de détournement de fonds à Madagascar*, on page eleven, below a piece about a cheese.

They had not read to the end.

The archive that Ravo Andrianasolo pushed into forty-one thousand mirrors that night had four parts, and the parts were like the four chambers of a heart: each necessary, each ugly, each pumping into the next.



The first part was the north.

In the far north of the island, in the laterite hills behind the Amber Mountain, there is a deposit of heavy mineral sands — ilmenite, zircon, monazite, and in the monazite the rare earths

that the twenty-first century cannot manufacture a single wind turbine, guided missile, electric motor or telephone without.

In 2017 that deposit had been surveyed by a state geological service and valued, conservatively, at four point one billion dollars.

In 2019 it had been sold.

Not the ore: the *concession*. Ninety-nine years, exclusive, with a stability clause that froze the tax regime for the duration and an arbitration clause that placed any dispute before a tribunal in a European city, in a language that no one in the villages above the deposit spoke. The buyer of record was a company called Cintra Resources Holdings SA, incorporated in Mauritius with a capital of one hundred thousand rupees, whose registered director was a Franco-Mauritian lawyer named Xavier Delcroix-Auber, and whose beneficial owner, through four layers of nominee arrangements that took Ravo's software nine hundred hours to peel, was — and this was the first thing in the file that made people put down their coffee — a trust in Liechtenstein whose named beneficiaries included two serving ministers of the Republic of Madagascar, one retired general, and the wife of the Director-General of an agency that officially did not conduct operations of any kind.

The state received a signature bonus of eleven million dollars.

The trust received, over four years, four hundred and six million.

The villages above the deposit received a road, which washed out in the first cyclone season, and a water tower that had never been connected to anything, and which children in the village of Ambondromifehy used, for years afterwards, as a place to sit and look at the sea.



The second part was the rice.

In February of the year before, Cyclone Vony had come ashore south of Toamasina at two hundred and thirty kilometres per hour, sat over the eastern seaboard for thirty-one hours, and left one hundred and forty thousand people without roofs, without rice, and in eleven communes without any road at all.

The world, as it does, sent things: forty-one thousand tonnes of rice, tarpaulins, corrugated roofing sheet, water purification tablets, four hundred tonnes of powdered milk, and cash.

The file contained the manifests. It contained the depot receipts. It contained, most damningly, the reconciliation spreadsheet that some functionary — some careful, exhausted, doomed functionary — had maintained honestly for eight months before someone noticed and had them transferred, and in that spreadsheet was a column headed *écart*, discrepancy, and the discrepancy was thirty-one per cent.

Thirty-one per cent of the roofing sheet had been sold. Not smuggled abroad: sold locally, in the affected communes, at four times the pre-cyclone price, by traders who had bought it from a warehouse in Toamasina that was leased by a company whose sole shareholder was a nephew.

They had stolen the roofs off the heads of people whose roofs had already been taken by God, and then sold the roofs back to them at a markup, and financed the purchase with a state loan guarantee.

There was an audio file with this section. Six minutes long. Two men in a car, one of them laughing about the price of tin.

In the weeks that followed, that six-minute clip was played in taxi-brousse stations from Antsiranana to Tolagnaro, over and over, on cheap phone speakers, in the heat, while people waited to travel. More than one driver reported that nobody spoke afterwards. They just stood there in the diesel smell, looking at the ground.



The third part was the sea.

Eleven industrial trawlers, flagged variously to three countries, licensed under a “scientific cooperation protocol” that had never been laid before the National Assembly, working the Mozambique Channel with bottom gear inside the twelve-mile limit where by law no industrial vessel may go, because the twelve-mile limit belongs to the pirogues.

The file had their transponder tracks. It had four years of them, scraped from satellite, showing the neat cynical dance of vessels that switch off their beacons at dusk and switch them on at dawn forty kilometres away.

It had the licence fees: three hundred and twelve thousand dollars a year, total, for the entire fleet. It had the estimated catch: two hundred and eleven million dollars a year.

And it had the letters. That was the thing about the file: it always had the letters. Eleven years of letters from fishing co-operatives in Ambanja, Nosy Be, Morondava, Belo-sur-Mer, Vezo communities who had fished that water since before there was a Republic, written in careful French, in careful Malagasy, in handwriting that got worse each year as the writers got older and no one replaced them, saying: *there are no more fish. Our children are hungry. We have written before. We received no answer. We write again, with respect.*

Each letter had a stamp on it. Received. Registered. Filed.

Somebody had filed them. For eleven years, somebody had opened those envelopes and stamped them and put them in a box, and that box was in the file too, photographed, four hundred and sixteen letters, and nobody who saw the photograph of that box ever forgot it.



And the fourth part was the Ninth Column.

The first eight columns of the master ledger were unremarkable to look at: reference, date, subject, function, category, method, location, cost. It was an operations ledger. Somebody's tidy mind had built it, the way tidy minds have built such things in every country that has ever had a state, and had maintained it for nineteen years across three administrations and two constitutions, because tidy minds outlive politics.

The ninth column was headed *Règlement*. Settlement.

Forty-one rows.

The categories were: *obstruction, persistent. Publication, hostile. Testimony, pending. Refusal, repeated. Inquiry, external.*

The methods were: *road. Water. Illness. Transfer. Detention, administrative. Fire.*

The costs ranged from four hundred thousand ariary to two hundred million.

And at the bottom of each of the nineteen annual sheets, in the summary block, next to a figure that represented a human being's entire remaining life converted into a number, there was a set of initials authorising the total.

For eleven of the nineteen years, the initials were N.R.



The forty-one names were, in order, and the file gave every one of them a page:

A hydrologist in Antsirabe who had published water-table data. A nun in Betroka who kept the receipts of a rice cooperative. Two customs clerks from Toamasina, the second of whom had been transferred to a post in the far south where the water was bad and had died there, aged forty-four, of an illness the file listed under *method*. A magistrate's clerk who had photocopied a docket. A blogger of twenty-six from Fianarantsoa whose last post was a photograph of a receipt. A Comorian deckhand who had seen containers being loaded at night. A radio journalist in Mahajanga. A schoolteacher who organised

a petition about a bridge. Seven names that the file listed as *identity uncertain* — men who had gone into a detention wing in a provincial gendarmerie and had come out under a different arithmetic. And, at number seven, a Deputy Controller of Manifests, Quay Four, Port of Toamasina, who on the twelfth of March 2009 had driven his Renault 4 down the Mandraka escarpment in the rain, as he had four hundred times, and had gone through the barrier at kilometre one hundred and eightysix into a gorge in which the recovery took nine days.

His son had been twenty-two, in the second year of an engineering course in Antananarivo, and had been told by a very kind police officer that the roads in the rain, monsieur, are dangerous, and that the brakes on those old Renaults, monsieur, you know how it is.

The son had known how it was. Everyone had known how it was. Knowing how it is, in a country where everyone knows how it is, is the cheapest and most useless commodity there has ever been, and Ravo Andrianasolo had spent twenty-two years and one billion four hundred million dollars converting *knowing how it is* into something with a signature on it.

That is what he uploaded at three minutes past three.

Not an accusation. Accusations are free.

A receipt.

Hanta, in the Rain

Journalism is the art of finding out what a man does not want printed. Everything else is public relations. In this country it is also the art of choosing which of your relatives will be visited.

— Hanta Ravelonarivo, editorial, 2 April

Antananarivo was drowning, as it does in April.

The rain came off the Ankaratra in grey sheets and fell on the twelve hills and on the rice paddies of the Betsimitatatra below them, and turned the red laterite of the unpaved streets into something with the consistency of blood pudding, and the whole city — the whole beautiful, stacked, impossible city of pastel houses and steep steps and jacaranda and rust — sat in the water and steamed.

Hanta Ravelonarivo had been up all night in a room over a photocopy shop in Isotry with three laptops, four telephones, and a chain-smoker from Reuters, and at nine minutes past three in the morning her oldest phone, the ugly one, the one whose number four people had, buzzed once on the table with a message from a number she did not know.

It said: *Ecoute-moi bien. Ouvre le lien. Publie tout. Ne me protège pas.*

Listen to me carefully. Open the link. Publish everything. Do not protect me.

She knew who it was from the fourth word. Ravo had been telling her not to protect him since they were nineteen, when he had said it about a philosophy exam he had not studied for, and it had been irritating then too.

They had been married for six years and divorced for eleven. The divorce had been the sort that leaves the architecture standing: they still spoke on Sundays, they still had a daughter, and Hanta still, at forty-three, occasionally caught herself composing sentences she wanted him to read.

She opened the link.

She read for forty minutes without speaking, and the man from Reuters, who had covered two coups and a famine and considered himself unshockable, watched a woman's face go through a sequence of changes he later described as *the most frightening thing I have ever watched happen to a person who was perfectly safe*.

At four in the morning she stood up, walked to the window, and looked out at the rain coming down on Isotry, on the tin roofs, on the market stalls folded up under tarpaulins, on a city of one and a half million people, and said, to nobody:

"They wrote it down."



Here is what people outside do not understand about Madagascar, and Hanta had spent a career failing to explain it in eight hundred words.

It is not that Malagasy people do not know their state steals. Of course they know. There is a proverb for it, there are seventeen proverbs for it, the taxi drivers have a joke for every ministry. A people who have survived colonisation, a monarchy, a first republic, a socialist experiment, structural adjustment, four coups, three famines, twelve cyclones a decade and the invention of the mobile telephone are not naïve about power.

It is that in Malagasy life the moral universe is not built out of law. It is built out of *fihavanana*: kinship, and the obligations of kinship, which run between families and villages and the living and the dead, and which are not sentimental. *Fihavanana* is a technology. It is what has kept people alive on this island through every one of those catastrophes: the certainty that if the rice fails, your cousin's cousin in the next valley is obliged, and if you break that obligation, the *razana* — the ancestors, who are not metaphors here, who are physically present in tombs on the hillsides and who are taken out every few years, wrapped in fresh silk, danced with and told the family news — the ancestors will know, and there will be *tsiny*, blame, and it will fall on your children.

A minister who steals a road is a thief. Everyone hates a thief. A thief is inside the system.

A ledger that prices a man's life at four thousand one hundred dollars and authorises it with initials, and files the widow's letters in a box, and does it for nineteen years across three administrations, is not a thief.

It is a family that has decided it has no relatives.

It is *fady*. Taboo. The unclean thing. The thing that must be dug up and dealt with or the whole house sickens.

Hanta knew, standing at that window at four in the morning with rain in her face, that she was not holding a corruption story.

She was holding a funeral.



She published at 05:00 with the Reuters man, and with a consortium of nine newsrooms that Ravo — of course, of course he had — had spent seven months quietly seeding through intermediaries, so that at 05:00 the same forty-one names went up in Paris and Johannesburg and Nairobi and London and Washington and Berlin and Delhi and Port Louis and, in a small

brave three-person newsroom above a hardware store in Antsirabe, in Madagascar itself.

At 05:04 the Malagasy-language version went out, which was the one that mattered, because it was the one that could be read aloud.

At 05:40 the first radio station in Toamasina read entry seven on air.

At 06:15 the national telecommunications regulator issued an instruction to the three mobile operators to throttle “certain applications” for reasons of “network hygiene.”

At 06:20 four hundred thousand Malagasy telephones, in a country that had been dealing with network hygiene for fifteen years, opened the VPN apps they already had.

At 07:00 Hanta Ravelonarivo’s mother, aged seventy-one, who lived in a small house in Ambohipo with a lemon tree and a cat, opened her door to two polite young men from the *Direction de la Coordination Territoriale* who wished to ask her a few questions about her daughter’s whereabouts, and who stood in her living room for forty minutes admiring the photographs on her wall, one by one, out loud, by name.

And this is the granddaughter? Miora, is it? Very pretty. In France, they tell me. Bordeaux? No? Where, then?

Her mother, who had lived through 1972 and 1991 and 2009 and had buried a husband and two brothers, gave them tea, and told them nothing, and when they left she sat down on the floor of her own kitchen and shook for an hour.

Then she got up, and walked four streets in the rain, and used a neighbour’s telephone, and said eleven words to her daughter.

They came. I am fine. Do not stop. Bury them.



By eight o’clock the government had made its first strategic error, which was to say nothing.

By eleven it had made its second, which was to say something.

The communiqué, read on national television by a spokesman with a beautiful voice and a visible tremor in his left hand, described the archive as “a fabrication of foreign origin, assembled by hostile interests seeking to destabilise the Republic and to seize its mineral patrimony,” and announced the opening of a judicial investigation into “the individual Andrianasolo, R., a person of foreign financial interests, for the crimes of espionage, treason, and endangerment of national security.”

Three things happened in the next four hours.

The first: a hashtag, in Malagasy, meaning *the box of letters*, which was shared eleven million times in a country of thirty-one million and which, by that evening, people had begun writing on walls.

The second: the price of the Republic’s dollar bonds fell nineteen per cent, and three foreign mining companies suspended due diligence on unrelated projects, and a Gulf sovereign fund with four hundred million dollars in a Malagasy port concession telephoned its lawyers in a state that the lawyers later described as *unprofessional*.

The third: in a blue-carpeted room on the ninth floor of a building on the Avenue de l’Indépendance that had no sign on it, a slim, soft-spoken, beautifully dressed man of fifty-eight named Nirina Ravelojaona read the words *Authorising initial: N.R.* on a screen, and understood, with the perfect clarity of a man who has spent nineteen years being the cleverest person in every room he enters, that he had one card left and that it was not a good one.

He picked up a telephone.

“Get me the north,” he said.

The Ninth Floor

The Directorate does not conduct operations. The Directorate coordinates.

— Statutory instrument 2004-118, Article 2

Nirina Ravelojaona was not a monster, and it is important to say so, because the comfortable thing about monsters is that there aren't many of them.

He had been born in 1968 in Fianarantsoa to a schoolteacher and a nurse. He had been the best student in his lycée and the second-best in the province. He had taken a scholarship to Paris in 1988 and read law and public administration and had come home in 1994, at twenty-six, into a country in the middle of an economic collapse so complete that his father's teaching salary had been worth, that year, eleven dollars a month.

He had watched his father — a man who had never in his life taken anything he had not earned, who had taught for thirty-one years, who had a drawer full of letters from former students who had become doctors — die at sixty-three in a public hospital in Fianarantsoa because there was no oxygen. Not because there was no money for oxygen. Because the oxygen had been signed for, and delivered, and had gone somewhere, and the nurse had wept and said *monsieur, il n'y en a pas*.

Nirina Ravelojaona had stood in that corridor at twenty-nine years old and had drawn from it precisely the wrong lesson, and had drawn it with the full force of a first-class mind.

The lesson was: *the system will not be fixed. Therefore the only question is where you stand inside it.*

He had risen without ever raising his voice. He was famous for it. He was courteous to secretaries, he remembered the names of drivers' children, he gave, genuinely and anonymously, a great deal of money to a school in Fianarantsoa, and in nineteen years he had never once signed anything that used a verb.

That was his craft. That was, in a sense, his entire art. The ledger said *settlement*. It said *method: road*. It said *category: obstruction, persistent*. He had built a vocabulary in which nothing was ever done to anybody, in which files were *closed* and matters were *regularised* and individuals were *transferred*, and he had inhabited that vocabulary so completely for so long that on the morning of the second of April, reading his own initials at the bottom of a column that some algorithm had helpfully re-labelled **DEATHS**, he experienced something that he had not experienced since the corridor in Fianarantsoa.

He experienced the sensation of a word being applied to him.



The room on the ninth floor filled at eleven-forty.

The Minister of Strategic Resources came, and a Secretary of State who did not know why he had been invited, and the Director of the Gendarmerie, and a legal adviser to the Palace who had been told to come and listen and say nothing, and at the end of the table, in fatigues, with his beret folded through his shoulder strap, Général Bruno Rakotoson of the Groupement d'Intervention Spéciale.

Ravelojaona let them talk for nine minutes. They talked about foreign interference, and about the electoral calendar, and about whether the state broadcaster should run a documentary about the man's foreign business dealings.

Then he said, quietly, and everyone stopped:

“Gentlemen. In two days, no one in this country will be talking about the mine, or the fish, or even the rice. Those are policy. Policy can be survived. In two days they will be talking about the ninth column, and about the box of letters, because those are not policy. Those are *fady*. And when a thing becomes *fady* in this country, we do not have arguments about it. We have funerals.”

He turned a page.

“There is one fact in our favour and it is a large one. The archive was released by a single named individual with a face, a fortune, foreign passports, and a habit of buying land. That is not a movement. That is a man. If the story stays *the state has been keeping a ledger of the people it kills*, we lose the country in nine days. If the story becomes *a foreign-financed billionaire attempted to seize the north and the state prevented him* — we survive.”

The legal adviser to the Palace, who had been told to say nothing, said: “And how does that story get written?”

Ravelojaona did not look up.

“By him being wrong about something,” he said. “Publicly. Preferably violently.”

Général Rakotoson leaned forward and put a folder on the table, and it was the fact that he had brought a folder that told everyone in the room that the phone call at eleven-fifteen had already been made and that the meeting they were sitting in was a formality with witnesses.

“We have a file on Vatofotsy,” the général said. “We have had a file on Vatofotsy since 2021, because of the airspace.”

“Summarise it.”

Rakotoson opened it, and read for four minutes, and as he read the room got very quiet, and the Secretary of State who did not know why he had been invited began, without being

aware of it, to fold and unfold the corner of a napkin until it came off in his fingers.



The summary, in the version later entered into evidence, ran as follows.

Subject property: peninsula of Vatofotsy, commune rurale of Ramena, district of Antsiranana II. Area four hundred and ten hectares. Access by land: one road, eleven kilometres, single track, three bridges, all three privately owned and rated by their builder at sixty tonnes with published engineering certificates that appear to be genuine. Access by sea: two coves, both fringed by reef, charted depths permitting landing craft at one state of tide only. Access by air: unrestricted in law; in practice see paragraph nine.

Structures: one restored colonial signal station; one modern residence of reinforced construction, floor area two thousand one hundred square metres, of which an estimated sixty per cent is subterranean; nineteen outbuildings; one medical facility with two operating theatres; one desalination plant; one power station, diesel-electric, four megawatts, with a photovoltaic array of one point one megawatts and a battery installation whose declared capacity is nine megawatt-hours. Water: three artesian bores plus desalination. Declared food storage: ninety days for two hundred persons. Assessment: the figure of ninety days is conservative.

Legacy structures: the French coastal battery of 1942, comprising two gun emplacements, a magazine, and one thousand four hundred metres of tunnel cut into granite, all of which the proprietor has restored under a heritage permit issued by the Ministry of Culture in 2022.

At this point the Minister of Strategic Resources said, “Restored.”

“Restored,” agreed Rakotoson.

“The guns as well?”

“One of the guns as well.”

There was a silence.

“It is a museum piece,” said the Minister. “It is a hundred years old.”

“It is eighty-three years old,” said Rakotoson, “and it is a naval gun of one hundred and thirty-eight millimetres, and it does not require electricity, or satellites, or a supply chain, and it covers both of the coves and eleven kilometres of the approach road, and the proprietor has a heritage permit to fire it twice a year on commemorative occasions, which he has done, in the presence of the sub-prefect, four times.”



Paragraph nine, Rakotoson read, concerns the electromagnetic environment.

Since 2022 the property has operated a private radio-astronomy installation registered with the ITU. In 2023, on four occasions, aircraft transiting within eleven nautical miles reported satellite navigation anomalies. In 2024 a survey aircraft chartered by the Ministry of Mines reported total loss of satellite navigation, degradation of radio altimetry, and spurious traffic-collision alerts at a range of nineteen kilometres, and returned to Arrachart aerodrome by visual reference. A complaint was filed. The response, from a law firm in Geneva, ran to sixty-one pages and asserted the installation’s compliance with every relevant instrument, and included an offer to submit to inspection by the International Telecommunication Union, which offer the Ministry did not take up.

Assessment: the proprietor is able, at will, to deny satellite navigation and a substantial portion of the radio spectrum within a radius of at least twenty kilometres of the peninsula, and has demonstrated this capability under conditions of plausible deniability on at least three occasions.

Rakotoson closed the folder.

“Sir. There is also the question of the personnel.”

“Go on.”

“The property employs, on declared contracts, with tax paid, two hundred and six persons. Of these, one hundred and forty-one are local: cooks, drivers, masons, gardeners, boatmen, a schoolteacher, four nurses. Sixty-five are what the contracts describe as ‘site protection and technical services.’ Of the sixty-five, we have identified forty-nine. They include eleven former French Foreign Legion, of whom four are from the parachute regiment; six former South African special forces; four Norwegians of whom two we assess as former Jegerkommando; nine Malagasy former gendarmerie *Groupe Spéciale*, all of whom left the service in 2019 or 2020” — Rakotoson paused here, one beat, because everyone in that room knew what had happened in 2019 and 2020 and who had signed it — “and a person we have not identified who has been photographed twice and who our analysts believe to be responsible for the drone architecture.”

“The drone architecture.”

“The proprietor has filed, publicly, eleven patents relating to counter-drone systems. Reading the patents, our technical staff assess that the peninsula is protected by an integrated air-defence system of the type normally associated with a naval task group, at a scale of engagement suited to targets under five hundred kilograms, comprising a distributed acoustic and radar sensor mesh, an electronic warfare capability of significant sophistication, and a launched interceptor swarm which the patents describe, in the abstract, as ‘a cooperative aerial denial mesh’ and which the site personnel are recorded on an intercept as calling *moka*.”

The legal adviser to the Palace, who had been told to say nothing, said: “Mosquitoes.”

“Mosquitoes,” said the général.



Nirina Ravelojaona sat for a long moment with his fingertips together.

Then he asked the question that, when it was read out at the Commission eleven months later, made three of the seven commissioners take off their glasses.

“How many men would it cost,” he said, “to take it in a night?”

Rakotoson did not answer immediately. He was, whatever else he was, a professional, and a professional is a man who has counted.

“To take it in a night,” he said, “with the certainty of taking it, and accepting that the ledger publishes anyway on his death, which it will — a reinforced battalion, both transport helicopters, the two Mi-17s that are serviceable, the patrol vessel, and the loss of, I would estimate, one hundred and forty to two hundred men.”

“Out of?”

“Out of six hundred.”

Nobody said anything.

“And that estimate,” Rakotoson added, “assumes he does not fight.”

“Explain.”

“It assumes he does what a rich man does when soldiers come, which is to shoot for ten minutes to protect his dignity and then negotiate. If he actually fights — if the sixty-five fight, and they are not conscripts, sir, they are the most expensive human beings on this island and they have been rehearsing this for four years — then I would need the whole intervention group, both battalions of the first regiment, foreign air support that we would have to ask for and would not receive, and I would be asking you to accept casualties in a single night that this country has not taken since 1947.”

The Minister of Strategic Resources said, with the exasperation of a man who has never been shot at, “It is *one house*.”

Général Bruno Rakotoson looked at him with an expression that several people in the room remembered for the rest of their lives.

“It is not a house, Minister,” he said. “It is a fort, on a headland, with three hundred metres of cliff, one road, and an air defence system, held by sixty-five professionals who cannot surrender because the man they work for has made surrender legally meaningless, and it is provisioned for ninety days, and it is broadcasting.”

He gathered his folder.

“With respect. Napoleon took Malta in three days because somebody opened a gate. Nobody in that place is going to open a gate. They *like* him.”

Vatofotsy

Every fortress ever built has fallen. Ask what it bought while it stood.

— Inscription cut into the lintel of the old signal station

You have to see it to understand it, and almost nobody did, which was rather the point.

The peninsula of Vatofotsy comes off the coast north-east of Antsiranana like a fist at the end of an arm: eleven kilometres of scrub and red rock, narrowing to a granite headland that stands three hundred and four metres above the Indian Ocean, with the ocean on the east and, on the west, the enormous blue mouth of one of the finest natural harbours in the world — the bay that the British came for in 1942 and that the French had fortified in 1904 for exactly the reason that everyone since the Portuguese has understood: whoever holds this water holds the Mozambique Channel, and whoever holds the Mozambique Channel holds a third of the world's oil.

There is a sacred islet in the bay. There are white sand beaches with names like the Emerald Sea. There is a mountain of rainforest to the south where lemurs sing at four in the morning like something with a grievance, and there is, in the flowering season, an air so full of ylang-ylang that people who grew up here can smell their own childhood from a boat.

And on the fist of rock, invisible from the road, dug into a heritage-listed French battery, was the most heavily defended private residence in the southern hemisphere.



Ravo had not set out to build a fortress. He had set out to build a house, and had discovered — this is the thing about money, and the thing nobody warns you about — that at a certain scale, money does not buy things. It buys the removal of obstacles, and if you keep removing obstacles for eleven years without ever asking yourself *why am I removing these particular obstacles*, you end up somewhere you could not have described at the start.

It had begun with the geckos. He had bought the peninsula in 2019 because it was cheap and because it was where his mother's family had come from and because there was, genuinely, an endemic species of blue-eyed day gecko on it. He had registered it as a private reserve. He had built a small house.

Then, in 2020, a man from a ministry had come up the road in a Land Cruiser and had explained, over a glass of rum, with enormous courtesy, that the reserve's status was under review, and that there was a fee, and that the fee was not, of course, official.

Ravo had paid it.

He had spent the following night on the terrace, not sleeping, thinking about his father in the rain on the Mandraka.

And in the morning he had called an engineering firm in Cape Town.



The road came first. Eleven kilometres of it, single track, cut into the flank of the peninsula, with three bridges over three ravines. He built them to sixty tonnes and published the certificates, which was a piece of theatre nobody understood at the

time: he wanted it known, publicly and on paper, that the bridges could take an armoured vehicle. He also built them, quietly, so that any of the three could be dropped into its ravine in four seconds by a man turning two keys, and so that dropping them would destroy nothing but the deck.

Then the water. Three artesian bores through four hundred metres of rock, plus a desalination plant sized for six hundred people, plus a cistern in the old magazine holding eleven thousand cubic metres, which he stocked with tilapia because his great-aunt said a cistern with fish in it is a cistern that tells you when it is poisoned.

Then the power: four megawatts of diesel with three years of fuel in bunkers cut into the rock at a depth where nothing short of a purpose-built weapon would reach them; a photovoltaic array on the western slope; nine megawatt-hours of battery in a hall with its own fire suppression; and, because his engineers had laughed at him, a nineteenth-century-style flywheel room, four tonnes of spinning steel, that could hold the sensors and the radios up for eleven minutes with no electronics involved at all.

Then the walls. The residence was not a building so much as a series of concrete cells stitched into the granite, each one able to be sealed, each with its own air, each connected to the 1942 tunnels — fourteen hundred metres of them, French military engineering of the sort they don't make any more, dug by men who assumed a battleship might one day be shooting at them and who had therefore not economised.

Then the eyes.



The Kite flew at three hundred metres on a Kevlar tether, a fat white aerostat that the locals had named *ny tsipoy*, the balloon, and that children on the Ramena road used to navigate home. It carried an electro-optical and infrared ball that could read a

licence plate at eleven kilometres and count the men in an open boat at nineteen.

Below the Kite: four radar masts, two of them mmWave, sweeping low and slow for anything that moved between the ground and a hundred metres, which is where drones live.

Below the radars: the acoustic mesh. Four hundred and twelve microphones on the peninsula and on buoys out to five kilometres, feeding a system that had been trained on eleven thousand hours of audio from the world's helicopters, outboard motors, diesel trucks and drone rotors, and that could tell you not merely *aircraft* but *Mi-17, two of them, twenty-two kilometres, closing at one hundred and ninety knots, one of them has a bad tail rotor.*

Below the acoustics: the geophones. Ninety of them, in the rock, for footsteps and vehicles.

And in the water, running the whole eleven-kilometre arc of the peninsula at a depth of thirty metres, the thing Ravo was proudest of and which had cost more than everything above it combined: a hydrophone necklace, four hundred sensors, that heard a swimmer's exhalation at eight hundred metres and a boat's propeller at forty kilometres and, twice a year, whales.

All of it came together in a hall inside the rock where nine hundred processors chewed through it, and out the other end came a single moving picture of everything within twenty kilometres of Vatofotsy that was larger than a bird, and a voice, a dead woman's voice from Ambanja, that would say, in Malagasy, *my child, something is coming.*



The teeth were simpler, and there were three sets.

The first set was electronic and Ravo loved it best, because it hurt nobody. They called it the Choir: a phased array under a radome that looked like a water tank, which could, within twenty kilometres, tell an incoming aircraft's navigation receiv-

er a beautiful and detailed lie. Not noise — noise is a declaration of war. A lie. It could put a helicopter forty kilometres to the west of where it was, gently, over eleven minutes, so that the pilot never noticed the moment it started; it could persuade a drone's autopilot that it had already arrived; it could take the datalink of a hostile aircraft and, without breaking it, make the video that came down the link nineteen seconds old.

The second set was the mosquitoes. Four hundred and eleven of them, in tubes cut into the cliff face, each the size of a dinner plate: interceptor drones, launched in waves, half of them carrying nothing but a spool of Dyneema net, the other half carrying nothing at all except themselves and a closing speed of two hundred and forty kilometres an hour. Njiva, who was nineteen and who had built the swarm's cooperative logic in a language he had partly invented, refused to let anyone call them weapons. *They are a wall*, he would say. *A wall that you have to build again every time.*

And the third set was the guns, and about the guns Ravo was neither proud nor sentimental.

Sixty-five people; every one of them armed to a standard that would have embarrassed a NATO rifle company; four remote weapon stations under armoured cupolas covering the road, the two coves and the northern approach; three anti-materiel rifles that could stop a truck at two kilometres; and, in the old emplacement on the seaward side, under a canvas cover, restored to functioning order by a retired Breton armoureder who had wept when he saw it, the 1942 gun.

One hundred and thirty-eight millimetres. Eleven metres of steel. It could throw a shell weighing forty kilograms nineteen kilometres out to sea.

Ravo had two hundred rounds for it, of which one hundred and eighty were inert practice shot: solid steel, no explosive, entirely legal to own, entirely legal to fire on a heritage permit,

and — as three hundred years of naval history will tell you — entirely capable of removing the bow of a landing craft.



But the thing that made Vatofotsy unassailable was none of that, and both Ravo and Fanja knew it, and it was the thing that Général Rakotoson had put his finger on in the blue-carpeted room and that Nirina Ravelojaona had refused to hear.

It was the one hundred and forty-one.

The cooks, the masons, the boatmen, the drivers, the gardeners, the four nurses, the schoolteacher who taught sixty-one children in a building Ravo had put up in the village of Ramena because the state school had two hundred pupils and eleven desks.

They were not staff. They were, in the way this island has always worked and always will, *havana*. Kin. Half of them were related to the other half. Their mothers had gone to school with each other's mothers. Their grandparents were in the same tombs on the same hillside, and every four or five years they went up that hillside together with a brass band and took the bones of their dead out into the sun, and wrapped them in new silk, and danced with them, and told them what had happened in the family since last time.

The commander of the intervention group had asked for a plan that assumed someone would open a gate.

There was no one at Vatofotsy who would open a gate, because there was no one at Vatofotsy for whom Ravo Andrianasolo was not, in some traceable and obligatory way, a relative — and because there was no one at Vatofotsy who had not, at some point in the previous eleven weeks, been read the ninth column out loud in their own language by a seventy-one-year-old woman named Solange Razafy, in a kitchen that smelled of ginger and clove, who had put her finger on the page at entry twenty-nine and said:

That one. That was Bakoly's brother from Antalaha. They told her he drowned.

The Tax Inspectors

Day one they send a piece of paper. Day two they send a man with a piece of paper. Day three the paper stops coming.

— Fanja Rasoanaivo, briefing to site personnel, 2 April

The first attack on Vatofotsy came at 11:40 on the second of April and consisted of four vehicles, nineteen men, and a folder.

Fanja watched them from four kilometres out through the Kite's eye: two white Land Cruisers of the Tax Directorate, one gendarmerie pickup, and behind them, incongruous as a dinner jacket at a funeral, a black Prado with tinted windows and Antananarivo plates that the system's registry lookup returned as belonging to a car hire company that had gone out of business in 2016.

"Sixteen in uniform," she said. "Three not. The three not are in the Prado and they are wearing plate carriers under their shirts, because look at the shoulders, and they have not opened the doors of that car in twenty-two minutes in this heat, which means it has air conditioning and they are not in a hurry."

Beside her, on the terrace, Ravo said: "So it's a look."

"It's a look, and it's a map. They will ask for something they know we will refuse, and while we refuse it they will count our cameras and time our response and see who talks to whom. If I were them I would send a very junior officer with a very stupid demand and let him be humiliated, because a humiliated junior

officer generates paperwork, and paperwork generates a legal basis, and a legal basis is what they don't have yet."

"And if you were us?"

Fanja lit a cigarette with her left hand.

"If I were us," she said, "I would give them tea."



They gave them tea.

This became, later, one of the most-watched pieces of footage of the entire affair, because Vatofotsy livestreamed it — four cameras, unedited, with a running timestamp and a caption bar in Malagasy and French, on nine mirrors simultaneously, and by 12:10 it had two hundred thousand concurrent viewers and by 14:00 the number had a comma in a different place.

The country watched a very young captain of the Tax Directorate, sweating in a shirt too big for him, stand at a gate in the sun and read a demand for the immediate production of eleven years of accounts, all customs declarations, the personnel register, and "all equipment of a telecommunications nature."

They watched a Malagasy woman of fifty-one in a linen shirt come out of the gate with two folding chairs and a thermos, set the chairs down in the shade, and invite him to sit.

They watched her hand him, without a word, a memory stick.

"Eleven years of accounts," she said. "Audited by Deloitte, filed with the Ministry every year on time, and mirrored publicly at this address since six o'clock this morning. Every ariary. Every salary. Every tax payment. Every invoice over one hundred euros. It is thirty-one gigabytes. You may also have it on paper if you have a truck."

The captain looked at the memory stick.

"Madame, I must also inspect the premises."

"Of course. Do you have a warrant from a judge?"

"I have an administrative order."

"Then you have a piece of paper signed by a man who is named forty-one times in a document that your mother is reading on her telephone right now." Fanja poured him tea. "Captain. What is your name?"

The camera caught it: the boy's eyes going to the lens, and away, and back.

"Rakotoarisoa," he said. "Fidèle."

"From?"

"Ambatondrazaka."

"Rice country." She nodded. "My grandmother was from Amparafaravola. Captain Rakotoarisoa, I am going to say something to you now in front of eight hundred thousand people and I want you to hear it as a professional and not as an insult. You have been sent here to be embarrassed. Not to inspect. To be embarrassed, on camera, so that a general in Antananarivo can write the word *obstruction* in a report tonight. You are the paperwork. That is all you are, to them. Drink your tea, take the memory stick, and write in your report — truthfully — that the site produced eleven years of accounts within four minutes of your arrival and offered full inspection under judicial warrant."

The young man sat in the shade for a long time.

Then he said, so quietly that the microphones nearly missed it and the sound engineers had to lift it in post: "My uncle is number thirty-three."

Fanja did not move.

"Rasolonjatovo," she said. "The radio journalist in Mahajanga."

"He was my mother's brother."

Nobody said anything for eleven seconds. Then the captain drank his tea, took the memory stick, stood up, put his cap back on, saluted — an odd, formal, entirely correct salute, to a civilian, in the sun — and went back down the road.

That clip went round the island in ninety minutes. By nightfall there were three songs.



The Prado did not leave with the others.

It sat at the bottom of the road for two hours and eleven minutes, and then reversed into a track, and then, at 16:20, one of its occupants got out and walked eleven metres into the scrub and unpacked, from a Peli case, a small quadcopter.

“There we are,” said Njiva.

He was nineteen years old, six feet of elbows, and he ran the swarm from a room in the rock with four screens and a rice-cooker he had refused to let anyone remove. He had grown up in Andavamamba, in Antananarivo, in a house where the water came up through the floor twice a year, and had been discovered at fifteen by a foundation Ravo funded and had never in his life been given a rule he did not want to test.

“Do we kill it?” asked Fanja.

“No.” Njiva was already typing. “It is a two-thousand-dollar Chinese aircraft. If we kill it they learn our engagement range. If we jam it they learn our jamming. If we do nothing they get eleven minutes of video of a wall.”

“So?”

“So we do the third thing.” He grinned; it changed his whole face. “We let it fly. We let it film. And we edit.”

The Choir woke up.

What the man in the scrub saw on his controller was a perfectly ordinary flight, eleven minutes long, over a compound: walls, a helipad, some vehicles, a white balloon on a cable. What the man in the scrub *actually* recorded was a video stream that had passed, in eleven milliseconds, through a system that had been fed four years of the compound’s own imagery and knew, better than any human, exactly what Vato-

fotsy looked like from every angle at every hour in every weather.

The version he took back to Antananarivo showed nineteen vehicles that did not exist, two radar masts in the wrong places, a gun emplacement that was actually a water tank, and — Njiva's own contribution, added at the last second over Fanja's objection and later described by an analyst in the Directorate as "the single most alarming thing in the packet" — a row of eleven shipping containers on the western slope, painted white, unmarked, with the doors open on darkness.

There were no containers on the western slope. There has never been anything on the western slope but scrub and a broken cistern.

The Directorate spent four days and a great deal of money trying to work out what was in them.



That night, Ravo held what his great-aunt insisted on calling *kabary* and everyone else called the six o'clock.

Two hundred and six people fit, at a squeeze, into the old magazine, which was the only space at Vatofotsy big enough, and which had a barrel-vaulted granite ceiling that made every voice sound like it was being taken seriously.

He stood on a crate. He was not a natural speaker; he had the engineer's habit of starting in the middle.

"You all know what I did last night," he said. "Some of you knew before. Most of you didn't, and that was deliberate, and if you are angry about it you are right to be, and I am not going to apologise for it because an apology is worth nothing tonight. What I am going to do is tell you the truth about your situation, which is a thing I can actually give you."

He held up a hand and counted off.

"One. The archive is out. It cannot be recalled by me, by them, by God. If they kill me it publishes wider. If they kill all

of us it publishes wider still. So the only thing that killing us now achieves for them is a photograph of the state killing two hundred people, which is the one thing they cannot afford. That is our shield. Understand that it is a strange shield: it works by making us *more* valuable dead than alive, which is only useful if the people who make the decision are rational. Some of them are not.”

“Two. They will not come tomorrow. They will come when they have a story. Right now the story is *the state is killing the man who found the ledger*. They need it to be *the state stopped a foreign plot in the north*. Everything they do for the next two weeks will be building that story. Tax inspectors. Drones. Leaks about my passports. Possibly a body somewhere with my name near it.”

“Three. Anyone who wants to leave, leaves. Tonight, tomorrow, in a week. Two boats and four vehicles are available at any hour and nobody will ask you a question or think a thought about you. Your salary is paid for two years either way; the money is already in a Mauritian account in your name, and Mamy has your papers, and I will not know who took the boat because I have asked not to be told.”

He stopped. His voice had gone somewhere he had not planned.

“Four. I have to say this part badly. My father was entry seven. I did not build this place to save the country. I built it because I was twenty-two years old in a corridor in Antananarivo and a policeman told me the roads are dangerous in the rain and I said *thank you, monsieur*, and I have been ashamed of saying thank you for twenty-two years.”

The magazine was very quiet.

“So this is not a heroic thing I am doing. It is a debt I am paying with money I did not deserve, and you are all standing in it. That is the truth. That is all the truth I have.”

He got down off the crate.

Nobody left that night, or the next night, or any night.

Twenty-two more people came *up* the road that week, from Ramena and from Antsiranana and one family from as far as Ambanja: cousins, in-laws, a fisherman whose brother was number twelve, two nurses, a mechanic, and a seventy-four-year-old man who had been a signaller in the French colonial army in 1958 and who arrived on a bicycle and asked, with enormous dignity, whether the battery still had its rangefinder.

It did. He worked it for nineteen days.

PART TWO



THE SIEGE

The First Night

Air defence is not about shooting things down. It is about making the other man's staff college arithmetic come out wrong.

— from the patent filings of R. Andrianasolo, US 11,942,206 B2

They came on the night of the sixth of April, four days after the upload, and they came the clever way.

Not helicopters. Drones.

Eleven of them, launched from a fishing boat forty kilometres to the north-east: fixed-wing, three metres of span, cheap enough to be deniable and good enough to be dangerous, of a type sold to nineteen air forces by a manufacturer whose brochures show them dropping mortar bombs on mannequins in a desert. Each carried two thermobaric charges of eleven kilograms.

Their target list, recovered later from a controller station in a warehouse near Arrachart, contained four items: the aerostat winch, the radome, the power hall's exhaust stacks, and the residence's eastern terrace, on which the proprietor took his coffee at six every morning and at nine every evening, a fact somebody had paid somebody eleven million ariary to confirm.

The acoustic mesh heard them at thirty-one kilometres.

Not the engines — two-stroke, muffled, quiet as a distant lawnmower. The *propeller blade rate*, a signature as specific as a face, which Vatofotsy's library had held for two years because Ravo had bought four of the same aircraft in 2023 from a deal-

er in Bulgaria for the express and only purpose of recording them.

Zanako, said his grandmother's voice, at 01:14. *Something is coming. Eleven things. They are the ones from the catalogue.*



What happened over the following nineteen minutes is now taught, in a sanitised and heavily redacted form, at three staff colleges.

Fanja did not sound the general alarm. She sounded *tsipoy* — the balloon — which meant: everyone below ground, in silence, except the eleven people whose job this was.

Njiva sat down in front of his four screens and put on a pair of headphones with one ear off, which was a thing he did, and cracked his knuckles, which was a thing Fanja had told him nineteen times not to do.

"Range thirty-one," he said. "They're at four hundred metres altitude, doing one hundred and forty. They'll descend at ten kilometres to come in under the radar horizon because that's what the manual says. The manual is on the internet."

"Choir?"

"Choir is warm. But listen —" He held up a finger, and this was the moment that Fanja later said she understood that the boy from Andavamamba was not a technician but an artist. "If I spoof them now at thirty-one kilometres, they'll fly into the sea and the operator will see eleven aircraft vanish and he will *learn something*. If I spoof them at eleven kilometres, they crash on land in front of the cameras and we have eleven intact airframes with serial numbers, and *he* learns nothing, because from where he's sitting they just went off the air over the target, which is exactly what happens when they work."

Fanja looked at Ravo.

Ravo said, "Do it the way that gets us the serial numbers."



At 01:31 the eleven aircraft descended, as the manual said, to sixty metres.

At 01:33 they crossed into the Choir's inner ring, and the Choir began, very gently, to lie.

It did not shout. It did not jam. It put out a signal only slightly stronger than the real one, and it moved — over ninety seconds, at a rate slower than any receiver's sanity check — the entire constellation of satellites eleven hundred metres to the west.

Eleven autopilots, running the same firmware, made the same correction. Eleven aircraft turned right by a degree and a half and settled onto a course that, according to every instrument aboard them, was perfect.

At 01:36 the Choir performed its second and crueller trick: it advanced their clocks.

Position is time. Every satellite navigation fix in the world is a stopwatch problem, and if you tell a receiver that light took a little longer to arrive than it did, the receiver will place itself, with total confidence, somewhere it is not.

The aircraft believed they were four hundred metres past the terrace.

They believed they had arrived.

Eleven autopilots, in eleven separate machines, executed their terminal manoeuvre — a pitch-over into a shallow dive, arming the charges at four seconds — over a slope of empty red scrub on the western side of the peninsula, one thousand one hundred metres from anything a human being had ever built.

Nine of them detonated.

The night went white and orange in nine places, and the sound came across the rock a heartbeat later like something enormous clearing its throat, and in the magazine two hundred

people felt it in their sternums, and a child began to cry, and Mamy Solange started, in an absolutely steady voice, to sing a hymn that everybody's grandmother knew, and by the third line ninety people were singing it, in the dark, under a granite ceiling built by frightened Frenchmen in 1942.

Two of the aircraft did not detonate. Their charges failed, as one in five of anything always fails.

At 06:00 Njiva went out and got them, and at 08:00 Vato-fotsy published high-resolution photographs of two intact airframes with legible manufacturer's plates, the export licence number stencilled under the wing root, and a maintenance sticker in a foreign alphabet — along with the acoustic recording, the flight tracks reconstructed from the wreckage, the crater survey, and a plain-language explanation of the spoofing that was accurate in every respect except the four details that mattered.

Ravo insisted on adding one line at the top of the release, and Fanja fought him on it for eleven minutes and lost.

Nobody was hurt. Nobody at Vatofofotsy fired a shot. We would like it noted that the eleven aircraft crashed one kilometre from any person, and that this was a choice.



In Antananarivo, at 09:40, an analyst put the photographs in front of Nirina Ravelojaona.

He looked at them for a long moment. The export licence number was the problem. The export licence number led to a broker in the Emirates, and the broker led to a payment, and the payment led to a facility, and the facility was in the file — the file that thirty-one million people now had on their telephones — as line four hundred and eleven of an annexe about defence procurement that no journalist had yet had time to read.

They had just handed the man an appendix.

“Sir,” said the analyst, “the technical staff want to know how he defeated eleven simultaneous—”

“He didn’t defeat anything,” said Ravelojaona.

“Sir?”

Ravelojaona set the photographs down and aligned their edges, which was a thing he did.

“We shot eleven arrows into a room in the dark,” he said, “and the man in the room caught two of them and has just posted a photograph of our fingerprints on the shafts. He did not defeat us. He *invoiced* us.”

What They Do Instead

You cannot reach the man. Very well. Reach the man's mother.

— Handwritten annotation, undated, exhibit 116

They stopped attacking Vatofotsy on the seventh of April, and this was, for Ravo, far worse.

Because the mathematics of Vatofotsy was solved. Fanja had solved it in 2022, on paper, in a document eleven pages long, and everything since had been engineering. The peninsula could not be taken from the sea without landing craft that could be sunk; it could not be taken from the air without an air force that could be blinded; it could not be taken from the road without three bridges that could be dropped; and it could not be starved inside ninety days.

The mathematics of everyone he loved was not solved and could not be.



They took Hanta on the eighth, at a checkpoint on the Route Nationale 4, in the rain, at 05:40, in front of eleven witnesses, four of whom filmed it.

Not violently. That was the horror of it. Two officers in clean uniforms, an administrative detention order, the word *espionage*, and a hand on her elbow of almost gentle courtesy as she got into the car. She had time to hand her telephone to the taxi driver — a man named Rado whom she had never met and

who kept that telephone in a rice sack under his floor for nineteen days and lied about it to two separate visits — and to say, loudly, to the cameras: “My name is Hanta Ravelonarivo. It is Tuesday the eighth of April, it is twenty to six, I am not injured, and I have not taken money from anyone.”

She said that last part because she knew what was coming.

By noon the state broadcaster had a photograph of a bank statement.



At Vatofotsy, Ravo watched the arrest video eleven times.

Then he went down through the tunnels to the deepest room, the one that had been a French shell store, and closed the door, and did not come out for two hours, and when Fanja finally opened it he was sitting on the floor with his back against the granite and his hands over his face.

“I did this,” he said.

“Yes,” said Fanja.

He looked up.

“You want me to say no?” She sat down opposite him, an old soldier’s careful sit, bad knee first. “You did this. She also did this. She published at five o’clock with her name on it and she is forty-three years old and she has been doing this since she was twenty-four and she did not require your permission. If you take her decision away from her and make it your fault, you are doing to her exactly what they do to everybody: you are turning a person into a consequence of a man.”

Ravo said nothing.

“Now,” said Fanja. “The daughter.”



Miora Andrianasolo was seventeen years old and had, at that moment, been at Vatofotsy for six days, having been extracted from a boarding school in Tamatave on the second of April by

four people she did not know in a way she considered melodramatic, unnecessary, and — this was the part that made her incandescent — *not discussed with her*.

She had her mother's face and her father's terrible stillness, and she had spent six days refusing to speak to him in any language, which given that they shared three was a considerable undertaking.

He found her on the eastern terrace at nine at night, which was the hour and the place his enemies had paid eleven million ariary to learn about, sitting on the wall with her legs over three hundred metres of nothing, eating a mango with a knife.

He sat down two metres away and looked at the sea.

After a while she said: "They took her because of you."

"Yes."

"You could have given it to a newspaper. Anonymously. Nobody would have known it was you and she'd be asleep in Ambohipo right now."

"Yes."

Miora turned. "Then why?"

And Ravo Andrianasolo, who had lied for eleven years to bankers, regulators, four governments and himself, told his daughter the truth, which he had not intended to do and never quite forgave himself for.

"Because an anonymous file is a rumour," he said. "This country has had four hundred anonymous files. They come out, and for two weeks everybody says *ah, you see, we knew*, and then a minister says *foreign fabrication*, and there is nobody to contradict him, because the file has no face and a rumour cannot be cross-examined, and in a month it is a joke in a taxi. I have watched it happen my whole life. Four hundred times."

He turned his hands over.

"A file with a name on it is different. A file with a name on it, attached to a man who cannot be arrested, cannot be disappeared, cannot be bought, cannot be starved and cannot be

shot — that file cannot be turned into a rumour. Because every day I am alive and standing on this rock is a day the file is *still being asserted by somebody*. That is what this place is for, Miora. Not to keep me alive. To keep the file *speaking*.”

His daughter was quiet for a while.

“That’s a really cold thing to say about Mum.”

“Yes,” he said. “It is.”

“Are you going to get her out?”

“I am going to try, and I am going to fail, and then I am going to do the thing that actually works, which is to make her more expensive to hold than to release. She’s already in eleven newspapers. On Friday she’ll be in a European parliament. Next week she will have an award from an organisation nobody in Antananarivo has heard of and everybody in Brussels has, and a bank in Mauritius will get a letter, and a mining company will get a letter, and a man who does not care about Hanta at all will telephone a man who does not care about her either, and she’ll be put on a road at four in the morning with no shoes and told to walk. That’s how it works. It is disgusting and it works and I have four hundred lawyers.”

Miora cut a piece of mango and held it out to him, which was the first thing she had given him in six days.

“You’re a really weird dad,” she said.

“I know.”

“Teach me the drones.”

“No.”

“Teach me the drones or I’m going to learn them from Njiva, who is nineteen and who has already offered.”

Ravo looked at his daughter for a long moment, and then out at the dark water where the pirogue lights were, and something in his chest that had been clenched since the second of April let go by one notch.

“Njiva,” he said, “is a menace.”

“Njiva,” said Miora, “is the best thing in this entire stupid castle, and if you had let me come here at Christmas like a normal father I’d already know how to fly them.”

Karakurt

We do not take contracts against states. We are frequently taken by them.

— Marketing material, Karakurt Group, 2023

The state's problem, by the tenth of April, was that it had run out of its own tools.

The gendarmerie would not go up that road; three commanders had said so in writing, which was itself an event. The intervention group would go, but Rakotoson's number had not changed and had in fact gone up, because everything he had learned since had made him more pessimistic and because he had begun, dangerously, to admire the opposition. The air force had two serviceable Mi-17s and a fleet of aircraft that could not navigate within twenty kilometres of the peninsula. And the navy's patrol vessel had a defect in its port shaft that had been reported in 2022, funded in 2022, and stolen in 2022.

So on the tenth of April a man named Iliya Marchev flew into Antananarivo on a Turkish Airlines flight with a Bulgarian passport and a business visa that said *agricultural consultancy*, and was met at the aircraft steps by a car with no plates.



Karakurt Group had one hundred and ninety employees, an office in Sofia, an office in Dubai, a helicopter maintenance facil-

ity in Uganda, and eleven years of contracts in places where the difference between a soldier and an employee is an invoice. It had put down a mutiny in one country, guarded a lithium concession in another, and had, in 2021, lost forty-one men in a single afternoon in a place its clients had assured it was permissive.

Marchev was fifty-four, with a face like a closed door, and he had two rules, both learned expensively.

The first was: *the client always lies about the enemy.*

The second was: *the client always lies about the terrain.*

He spent four days doing what nobody in the Malagasy state had done, which was to read all eleven of the man's patents, hire a naval architect in Piraeus to model the two coves, buy — at a cost of nineteen thousand dollars — three years of commercial satellite imagery of the peninsula, and sit in a hotel room in Antsiranana with a pair of binoculars and a Thermos, for eleven hours, watching a white balloon on a cable.

On the fifteenth he came back to the ninth floor and gave a presentation that lasted six minutes.

"You have three options," he said. "I will price all three, and then I will tell you which one I will accept, and it is not the same as the one you want."



"Option one. Deniable assault, night, sea, two coves, ninety men. Cost, eleven million euros. Probability of taking the site: below thirty per cent. Probability of my company being identified within forty-eight hours: one hundred per cent, because he has hydrophones and cameras and lawyers, and because he will film my dead and publish their tattoos. I decline option one."

"Option two. Overt assault with your forces, my company providing air, electronic warfare and command. Cost, twenty-two million. Probability of taking the site: seventy per cent.

Malagasy casualties: one hundred and fifty upward. My casualties: forty upward. Political outcome: the state kills two hundred people including cooks and nurses on live television. Gentlemen, I have been in this business a long time and I want to be very clear. There are countries where I would take that contract. If I take it here, I am not risking my men. I am risking my company, because a video of your soldiers shooting a schoolteacher in front of a nurse becomes, in eleven hours, a sanctions listing with my name on it. I price option two at twenty-two million and a fee schedule that will offend you, and I recommend against it.”

The Minister of Strategic Resources said, “And option three?”

Marchev put a photograph on the table.

It was the road. The eleven kilometres, and the three bridges, and at the bottom of it, where it met the coast road at the edge of the commune of Ramena, a village: four hundred houses, a market, a school, two churches, a mosque, and a beach with sixty pirogues drawn up on it.

“Option three,” said Marchev, “is that you do not attack the fortress at all. You cannot take the fortress. Anybody who tells you otherwise is selling you something. But the fortress is not the problem. The fortress is a rock with rich people in it and the world does not care about rich people in rocks.”

He tapped the village.

“The problem is *this*. He has ninety days of food for two hundred people. He has four hundred and eleven people. Do you know why? Because they keep coming up the road. Every day, more. And his water is fine and his power is fine but he is running an entire commune out of his larder, and the commune knows it, and every family that sends a boy up that road with a sack of rice on his back is making him stronger, not weaker.”

“So?”

“So you make it expensive to be his relative,” said Iliya Marchev. “You do not besiege the fort. You besiege the *fihavanana*. Roadblocks at Ramena, at Sakaramy, at the Antsir-anana junction. Every vehicle searched. Every boat inspected for ‘fisheries compliance.’ Every man who goes up that road has his identity card photographed and his employer telephoned. You do not arrest anyone. Arrests make martyrs. You simply make it take four hours instead of ten minutes, every single day, for eleven weeks, and you let people work out for themselves that having a cousin at Vatofotsy is bad for business.”

He sat down.

“Cost: two million euros and forty of my men in advisory roles. Probability of collapsing the site within four months: I would say sixty per cent, and it rises every week. Probability of a video of a dead schoolteacher: near zero. This is the option I will accept.”

There was a long silence in the blue-carpeted room.

Then Nirina Ravelojaona said, softly: “Four months.”

“Yes.”

“Mr Marchev. In four months there will be a commission of inquiry, an arrest warrant with my name on it in a European capital, and a president who has decided that I am the price of his own survival.” He smiled; it was a terrible smile, the smile of a very clever man at the exact moment he stops being clever. “I do not have four months. I have eleven days.”

Marchev looked at him for a while with the expression of a man who has just identified, at last, the actual hazard in the room.

“Then you do not have a security problem,” he said, and stood up, and buttoned his jacket. “You have a personal one, and I don’t take those.”

He flew out that night.

He was, in the end, the only professional in the entire affair who correctly predicted the ending, and he did it in one sen-

tence to his own second-in-command on the aircraft steps: *That man will burn a province to buy himself a week.*

Three Helicopters

Fear does not make men cautious. It makes them punctual.

— Fanja Rasoanaivo, deposition, p. 611

They came at 02:40 on the sixteenth of April, and the fact that they came at all is the single strongest evidence that by the sixteenth of April the decision was no longer being made by anybody who had ever been shot at.

Three helicopters: two Mi-17s of the air force with forty-eight men of the intervention group, and, leading, an Alouette with a general's staff aboard because somebody had insisted on a commander in the air.

Two patrol boats out of Antsiranana with a further thirty men, timed to arrive at the coves eleven minutes after the air assault.

And, at the bottom of the road, four armoured personnel carriers and two hundred and eleven gendarmes, whose orders — recovered later — were, in an almost touching admission of what everyone actually expected, *to secure the road for the recovery of casualties*.



Vatofotsy knew at 01:52.

Not from radar. From a woman named Bakoly Razanamalala, aged sixty-six, who sold fried bread and coffee outside the gate of Arrachart aerodrome and who had been

doing so since 1989, and who telephoned her sister's grandson at 01:51 to say that two big helicopters were turning their engines and that the soldiers had been sitting on the grass since midnight and that one of them, a boy from Diego with a bad tooth, had asked her if she knew any prayers.

Mamy Solange took the call in the kitchen on the HF set.

"They are lifting," she said, to a room full of people who had already begun, quietly, to move. "Bakoly says two of the big ones and one small. She says the boy with the tooth is crying."



At 02:11 the acoustic mesh confirmed it: three rotorcraft, forty-one kilometres, one hundred and sixty knots.

At 02:14 the hydrophone necklace picked up the patrol boats at nineteen kilometres.

At 02:19 Ravo Andrianasolo made the only decision of his life that he ever described, afterwards, as the correct one.

"Everybody in this room listen to me," he said, standing behind Njiva's chair in the rock. "There will be no lethal engagement of the aircraft. None. Not one round. Fanja, that is an order and I want it acknowledged out loud."

Fanja said, "Acknowledged," and then, "and it is the right order, and if you had given me the other one I would have refused it."

"Njiva?"

The boy from Andavamamba had his headphones half on and both hands open above the keyboard like a pianist.

"Boss," he said, "I can put all three of them in the sea in ninety seconds."

"I know you can. That is why they're going to lose."



Here is what happened, in the twenty-two minutes that the Antsiranana Commission's technical annexe describes with unusual dryness as *the aerial event*.

At 02:31, at nineteen kilometres, all three aircraft lost satellite navigation. Not abruptly. Gently: a drift, a disagreement between the two receivers on the lead Mi-17, a caution message that the flight engineer acknowledged and moved on from because it happens.

At 02:34, at fourteen kilometres, all three aircraft lost their radio altimeters to a low-power spoof that convinced the boxes they were four hundred metres higher than they were, over water, at night, on instruments — which is the single most frightening thing that can happen to a helicopter crew and which two of the three pilots handled correctly by climbing.

At 02:36, at eleven kilometres, the Choir stopped being subtle.

It reached into the tactical radios and did not jam them. It *delayed* them — every transmission, in both directions, arriving eleven hundred milliseconds late, which does not sound like much and which turns a formation of three aircraft into three aircraft that are shouting at each other from the past.

And then it played them their own voices.

Njiva had built the library in four days out of nineteen hours of intercepted air force traffic. It was crude. It did not need to be good. What came into the headsets of forty-eight men on a night infiltration, in their own language, in the voice of their own dispatcher, was:

Abort. Abort. Wave off, wave off, we have friendlies on the objective.

Sabotage. There are civilians. Repeat, there are civilians on the objective.

Where is Two? Two, where are you? Two has gone down. Two has gone in the water.

The lead pilot broke right. The second Mi-17 did not, because he had heard the abort call eleven hundred milliseconds later than the first pilot and had, therefore, seen his lead break away for no reason at all, at night, at ninety metres over water, with no satellite navigation and a radio altimeter that was lying to him.

At 02:38 the mosquitoes came out of the cliff.

Two hundred of them. Not at the helicopters: *around* them. Njiva put a shell of small aircraft into a cylinder of sky eleven hundred metres across and four hundred metres high, all of them with strobes, all of them with radar reflectors the size of a fist, all of them moving, and to the three flight crews inside that cylinder — on night vision, at ninety metres, on instruments that had been lying for seven minutes — it looked exactly, precisely, unmistakably like being inside a swarm of incoming missiles.

Not one of the four hundred and eleven mosquitoes touched an aircraft. Njiva's cooperative logic enforced a hard exclusion sphere of two hundred metres around every rotorcraft and would not have permitted it if he had ordered it, because he had written it that way in 2023 and had never told anybody, including Ravo.

The Alouette turned east and did not stop turning east until it was over the bay.

The lead Mi-17 climbed to six hundred metres, declared an emergency in clear on the international distress frequency — which Vatofotsy did not touch, because Fanja had personally drawn a red line through 121.5 in the operational order — and went home.

The second Mi-17 put itself on the beach.

Not crashed: *put itself*, in a controlled, professional, absolutely terrified running landing on the sand at Ramena, in front of the village, in the dark, at 02:44, with forty-eight rounds unfired and twenty-four men aboard who got out and lay down

on the beach and were, within eleven minutes, surrounded by roughly four hundred villagers in nightclothes holding telephones.

The footage from Ramena beach is the most-viewed video ever recorded in Madagascar.

It shows a Malagasy sergeant of the intervention group, aged thirty-one, standing on a beach in front of his own helicopter with his rifle held by the barrel in one hand, pointed at the sand, and an old woman in a *lamba* walking up to him and taking his face in both her hands like a grandmother, and asking him, on camera, in Malagasy, in a voice that carries:

Whose son are you?

And the sergeant saying, “Randriamalala, madame. From Sambava.”

And the old woman saying: *Then sit down, my child, and I will bring you coffee, because your mother is not here to be ashamed of you.*



The patrol boats never came in.

They stood off the northern cove at four kilometres and at 02:51 they received, on the marine VHF, in Malagasy and French, from a shore station whose licence number and operator's name were included in the transmission:

Antsiranana patrol, Antsiranana patrol, this is Vatofotsy radio. Be advised, our seaward battery is manned, the range to your vessel is four thousand one hundred metres, and we hold you. Be advised further that we will not fire on you, that this transmission is being broadcast live, and that our position and yours are being displayed to four hundred thousand people. We wish you a good night and a safe return to harbour.

And then, because Ravo could not resist and because Fanja was in the tunnel and did not hear it in time to stop him:

Vatofotsy is a nature reserve. Please observe the no-wake zone.



Total casualties on the night of the sixteenth of April: one broken ankle (a corporal, exiting the aircraft on the beach), one heart attack (a fifty-nine-year-old officer aboard the *Alouette*, who survived), and eleven million dollars of national dignity.

At 04:00, in the blue-carpeted room on the ninth floor, Nirina Ravelojaona sat alone and watched the beach video for the fourth time.

He watched the old woman take the soldier's face in her hands.

He was a clever man. He was, by some distance, the cleverest man in the Republic, and he understood what he was looking at with a completeness that nobody else in the building could match, and it is the reason for everything he did afterwards.

He was not watching a defeat.

He was watching the moment when the army stopped belonging to him.

Long Iron

The gun is eighty-three years old. It does not care what year it is.

— Yves Le Guennec, armourer, to the Commission

The men who said yes were not as good as the men who said no. This is the oldest rule in the business, and Serge Cazenave knew it better than anybody, because for nineteen years he had been the man who said yes.

He was fifty-one. He had been a good officer once, in a good regiment, and had left it in 2009 for reasons that appeared in a court file in Toulon, and since then he had done Iraq for money, Libya for more money, and four years in a country he would not name for an amount that had turned out, after the arbitration, to be nothing at all. He had a house near Perpignan with a mortgage on it and a daughter at a university he could not afford, and when a broker in Dubai called him on the eleventh of April and said *there is an island job, it is one house, the client is a state, the fee is four hundred thousand for eleven nights*, he had asked two questions.

The first was: *why is the fee so high?*

The second, when he heard the answer, was: *why did Marchev say no?*

The broker had said: *Marchev has become old.*

Cazenave, who was old too, and who had eleven days to find fifty-nine thousand euros, said yes.



He assembled sixty men in nine days: four Frenchmen, eleven Serbs, six Georgians, nine South Africans, two Australians, a Chilean, and twenty-seven Malagasy who had been recruited in Antananarivo bars in a fortnight and who had, between them, eleven years of military service, three of which belonged to one man.

He was given three landing craft belonging to a fisheries company, two rigid-hull boats, and a plan he had not written.

He read the plan on the aircraft and disliked it. He disliked it because it used the word *surprise* eleven times in six pages about a target that had a hydrophone array, and because it scheduled the assault for the only state of tide that would float his craft over the reef, which meant that anyone with a tide table and a chart knew precisely when he was coming, which meant it was not an assault, it was an appointment.

He raised this. He was told the timing was fixed by “political requirements.”

He should have gone home. He told the Commission so himself, three years later, in a courtroom in a European city, in the flat voice of a man who has stopped defending himself.

I knew, he said. I want that in the record. I knew on the aircraft.



At Vatofotsy they knew about the tide too.

“Northern cove, two hours before high water, moon set at 23:40,” said Fanja, at the six o’clock briefing on the twentieth. “Which gives them the twenty-first, the twenty-second and the twenty-third and after that the tides go wrong for a fortnight. So it is one of three nights, and it is the twenty-second, because on the twenty-first there is a fisheries meeting in Ramena that four hundred people are attending and even these people are

not stupid enough to do it in front of four hundred people, and on the twenty-third the weather turns.”

Ravo said, “And when they come?”

Fanja put down her pointer.

“When they come,” she said, “we will kill some of them.”

The room went still.

“I want to be extremely clear, because you have all had a very good three weeks and you have started to believe that this is a magic trick.” She looked around the magazine. “The drones we lied to. The helicopters we frightened. That worked because a helicopter crew has a hundred and forty other ways to die and one radio call gives them permission to live. Boats are different. Boats do not have a bad moment at ninety metres. Boats come in slowly, at four knots, on a dark night, in the exact place where the reef lets them, and a man in a boat does not turn round because his instruments are lying: he turns round because the boat is sinking.”

She let that sit.

“So we will not be frightening anybody on the twenty-second. We will be sinking empty water in front of them, twice, with the gun, and I will say to them on the radio: *the next one is you*. And if they keep coming after the second one, then they have made their decision in front of witnesses, and we will sink the boats, and men will drown.”

Mamy Solange, from the back, in Malagasy: “How many?”

“If they are sensible, none, madame. If they are stubborn, thirty.”

Ravo said, “And if we do nothing?”

“Then sixty men come ashore in the northern cove, and eleven of us die in the tunnels, and then we die too, and then everyone here who has a telephone dies, because they cannot afford witnesses. That is not a threat, Ravo, that is arithmetic. I have been in the building where they do the afterwards.”

Nobody spoke.

Then the old signaller, the man of seventy-four who had come up the road on a bicycle, said, in careful French:

“Madame, the rangefinder is good. I have checked it against the light on Nosy Lonjo. I can give the gun the range to eleven metres.”



They came at 00:41 on the twenty-second of April.

The hydrophones had them at 22:50 — three heavy diesels at nineteen kilometres, and the pattern was so unmistakable that the system did not even bother with probabilities; it simply said, in the voice of a dead woman from Ambanja: *my child, they are coming by sea and there are three big ones and two small.*

Vatofotsy went dark and quiet. Two hundred and eleven people went into the granite. Doctor Lalao Ranaivo, who was fifty-five and had spent nine years with Médecins Sans Frontières and had a mouth like a stevedore, laid out two theatres and swore continuously for forty minutes at nobody.

And in the seaward emplacement, under the canvas, eleven people took the covers off a French naval gun built in 1936, and the old signaller sat down at a rangefinder made of brass and glass and began, quietly, in the dark, to call numbers.



The first shot was fired at 00:52 at a range of four thousand two hundred metres and it was a solid steel practice shell weighing forty kilograms, and it went into the sea four hundred metres ahead of the lead landing craft and threw up a column of white water eleven metres high in the moonless dark.

The sound of it — the crack across the water, and then the enormous flat slap of the impact — reached Ramena eleven seconds later and woke four hundred houses.

On the radio, in French and Malagasy, on every marine channel, live to two hundred and ninety thousand people:

Unidentified vessels approaching the northern cove of the Vatofotsy reserve. This is Vatofotsy radio. That was a warning shot. It was fired four hundred metres ahead of your lead craft with an inert projectile. We have your range, your course and your speed. We are broadcasting this transmission publicly. Turn about now.

Cazenave's craft kept coming. Of course they did. They were nineteen minutes from the beach and four hundred thousand euros from Perpignan.

The second shot was fired at 01:01 at two thousand nine hundred metres and it went into the water one hundred and ten metres off the lead craft's port bow, and this time the crew felt it: the concussion through the hull, the spray coming over the ramp, the sea slapping like a hand.

That was one hundred metres. The next one will not be a warning. Turn about.

And Serge Cazenave, standing in the wheelhouse of a fisheries landing craft with sixty men behind him and a fee he had already spent, did the arithmetic that every professional does at the moment the plan stops being a plan, and gave the order that saved forty-one lives and ended his career.

"Demi-tour."

Turn about.



Two of the three craft turned.

The third did not, because aboard the third was a man named Petar Kolev who had been paid a separate fee by a separate person for a separate task, which was to reach the shore whatever the leader did, and to reach it with eleven kilograms of explosive and four men, and to put it on the aerostat winch — because somebody in the blue-carpeted room had finally un-

derstood that the balloon was the eye and that the eye was the story.

The rigid-hull boat came in past the turning landing craft at thirty-one knots.

It made it to the reef.

Kofi Adjei was forty-four years old, from Takoradi, and had spent eleven years in the Ghana Navy's special boat unit before a knee and a divorce took him into private work; he had run Vatofotsy's water side for four years; he had taught nineteen local boys to dive; he had a wife in Accra and no children and a habit of humming while he worked that everyone found either soothing or unbearable.

He was in the water at the reef edge because that was the plan, and the plan was that the reef was the only place a small boat could cross, and that the crossing would be denied by a net.

The net worked. The boat's propellers took it at thirty knots and the drives failed instantly, and the boat slewed and stopped dead, four hundred metres off a black cliff, and four men who had been going to shore were suddenly four men in a disabled boat under a gun.

And one of them, in the confusion, in the dark, at eleven metres, fired.

He fired at nothing. He fired at the sound of a swimmer's fin, and he emptied a magazine into black water in a panic that his own team leader later described in a Bulgarian sentence that cannot be translated, and one of the rounds — a single round, out of thirty-one — found Kofi Adjei under the left collarbone.

They got him out in nine minutes. Lalao Ranaivo had him on a table in eleven. She worked on him for two hours and forty minutes with two nurses and a boy of twenty holding a light, and at 04:11 on the twenty-second of April she came out into

the corridor with her hands still up and her mask down and said, to Ravo Andrianasolo:

“No.”



They did not sink the third boat.

Fanja gave the order not to, and it was the hardest order she ever gave, and she gave it eleven seconds after being told that Kofi was hit.

They took the four men off it instead, at gunpoint, in the dark, and they were photographed and their names were taken and their weapons were bagged and tagged with the care of a scene-of-crime unit, and at 07:00 Vatofotsy handed all four of them — alive, uninjured, fed — to the gendarmerie post at Ramena, in daylight, on camera, with a dossier, in front of the village.

The old woman who had taken the soldier’s face in her hands on the sixteenth stood at the front of the crowd and watched them go past, and said nothing at all, and that photograph — the four mercenaries walking to the police truck between two rows of silent villagers in the morning light — won a prize the following year that its photographer, a nineteen-year-old from Ramena with a cracked telephone, did not attend, because she was in her final school examinations.



They buried Kofi Adjei on the twenty-fourth on the western slope, above the scrub where the eleven drones had crashed, facing the sea.

The state would not permit a flight to Accra. The state, at that point, would not have permitted a letter.

His wife watched the funeral on a livestream from a house in Accra at four o’clock in the morning with her sister and eleven neighbours, and afterwards Mamy Solange sat in front of a

camera alone in the kitchen with the ginger and the clove behind her and spoke to her for six minutes in French, of which the only sentence that anybody remembers is the last one:

Madame, I am seventy-one years old, and I will tell you what my mother told me: we do not bury people here, we only put them down for a while. When this is finished, we will dig your husband up, and we will wrap him in silk, and we will dance with him, and then we will put him on an aeroplane and send him home to you. That is a promise from an old woman. It is the only kind that counts.

They did, in November of the following year.

The Rat in the Wall

Treason is almost never a decision. It is a series of small accommodations, each of which is survivable.

— Antsiranana Commission, Vol. II, para. 44

They found the leak on the twenty-sixth, and it was a boy.

His name was Tsiky Rakotomavo and he was twenty-three and he had been the compound's second diesel mechanic since 2022, and he was, by every account including Fanja's, a good one: patient with old engines, unbothered by heat, the sort of young man who leaves a workshop cleaner than he found it.

The Kite's coffee had been the giveaway. That is to say: somebody had known that the aerostat winch was serviced on Tuesdays and Fridays and that between 05:40 and 06:10 on those mornings the winch house was empty, and that fact had been in the target packet of the rigid-hull boat, and there were eleven people on the peninsula who knew it, and Njiva — who had been awake for four days and had gone somewhere unpleasant inside himself since Kofi died — wrote a piece of software that compared those eleven people's telephone activity against the times of nine leaks and got an answer in forty minutes.

Not a call. Nothing so crude. A pattern of *durations*: a boy who went out to the road every four days to a spot where the

network reached, and stood there for eleven minutes, and came back.

They brought him into the old signal station at eleven in the morning.

He did not deny it. He did not last four seconds. He came apart the moment Fanja said his mother's name, and what came out of him, in Malagasy, so fast that the translator on the recording gives up twice, was this:

They had his brother.

Not arrested: *hosted*. His younger brother Fetra, nineteen, a second-year student at the university in Antsiranana, had been picked up on the fourth of April on a matter concerning a stolen motorcycle, and was being held in the gendarmerie at a town four hours away without charge, and every four days a man telephoned Tsiky and put Fetra on the line for eleven seconds so that Tsiky could hear that he was still all right, and then the man asked Tsiky a question, and Tsiky answered it.

Nine times. He had answered nine questions.

The ninth one had been about Tuesday and Friday mornings, and a man from Takoradi was dead.



They put him in a storeroom with a mattress and a guard and Fanja came to find Ravo on the terrace, and she was, for the first time in four years, angry with him before he had said anything.

"I know what you are going to do," she said.

"Do you."

"You are going to forgive him, in public, on camera, because it is beautiful and because it makes them look like monsters and because you cannot bear to be the man who punished a boy for loving his brother." She lit a cigarette with her left hand. "And I am telling you, as the person responsible for two hundred and eleven lives, that you cannot. Because there are

four hundred people on this rock now and every single one of them has a brother, and if the price of betraying us is a hug and a livestream, then by Friday we will have nine Tsikys.”

Ravo was quiet a long time.

“You’re right,” he said.

“I know I’m right.”

“You’re right and I’m going to do it anyway, and I’m going to make it cost him more than a punishment would.”



What he did was this, and it is the reason that a certain kind of person, to this day, finds Ravo Andrianasolo more frightening than any of the guns.

He put Tsiky Rakotomavo on camera. Live. Unedited. Forty-one minutes.

He sat next to him — not opposite, next to — and he said, in Malagasy, to a live audience that peaked at one million one hundred thousand:

“This is Tsiky. He is twenty-three. He works on our generators and he is better at it than anyone here. Nine times he has given information about this place to the people who are trying to kill us, and one of the things he told them helped them to kill a man I loved. He is going to tell you why, in his own words, and I am not going to interrupt him, and then I am going to tell you what happens to him.”

And the boy — grey, shaking, twenty-three years old, in front of a million people — told them about his brother, and about the eleven seconds every four days, and about the man’s voice on the telephone, and about the moment he understood what Tuesday and Friday meant, which was after, not before.

Then Ravo said:

“Nothing happens to him. He keeps his job. He keeps his salary. He sleeps in his bed tonight.”

He turned to the camera.

“And now I am going to speak to the people who did this. You are watching. I know exactly who you are; you are in annexe fourteen. You took a nineteen-year-old boy over a motor-cycle he did not steal, and you rented him back to his brother eleven seconds at a time in exchange for the coordinates of a winch house.

“So here is where we are. Fetra Rakotomavo is now the most famous nineteen-year-old in this country. In four minutes his photograph will be on every mirror we have. Four hundred lawyers in nine countries have his name. Two European parliaments have his name. The special rapporteur has his name. And if that boy so much as catches a cold in your custody, the *only* story on this island for the next year will be his cold.

“You made him a hostage. I have just made him a monument. You cannot hurt a monument, you can only build it higher.

“Release him, and this is over, and I will never say your name again. Keep him, and I will make you famous.”



Fetra Rakotomavo was released at 04:40 on the twenty-eighth of April, without charge, on a road outside a town four hours from Antsiranana, with no shoes, and told to walk.

He walked eleven kilometres and was picked up by a taxi-brousse driver who refused his money.

Hanta Ravelonarivo was released on the thirtieth, at 04:00, on a road outside Antananarivo, with no shoes, and told to walk.

She walked, too. She walked four kilometres in the dark to the first place with a light, which was a bread oven in Ambohipo, and the baker gave her a stool and a piece of *mofo gasy* and did not ask her a single question, and she sat there until it got light, and then she borrowed his telephone.

She did not call her daughter, or her mother, or Ravo.

She called her editor, and she said: "I'm out. What's moving?"



Tsiky Rakotomavo worked at Vatofotsy for nineteen more days and never once looked anybody in the eye.

On the seventeenth of May, at 04:20, during the thing that came afterwards to be called the Line, he did something on the north wall that this account will come to in its place.

His name is on the memorial. It is fourth.

Blackout

They turned off the province. Nobody in the province noticed for about an hour, because we are used to it.

— Testimony of a Ramena fisherman, laughing, Vol. VI

On the second of May, at 20:11, the Republic of Madagascar turned off the north.

It was done by administrative instruction, under a state of emergency proclaimed that afternoon in the districts of Antsir-anana I and II, and it had four parts, and it was, of everything that was done, the piece of statecraft that came closest to working.

They took the submarine cable landing station off line “for maintenance.”

They shut the three mobile operators’ towers in nine communes.

They cut the high-voltage line from the hydro plant, and the province went to candles.

And — this was the clever part, the part that had Ravelojaona’s fingerprints on it — they issued a licensing order suspending all “non-governmental satellite telecommunications” in the emergency districts, and they filed, simultaneously, through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, formal notice to four satellite operators in three countries that any service provided to a terminal within the affected coordinates would constitute a violation of Malagasy law by the operator itself.

Three of the four operators, at 22:00, suspended service to the coordinates.

At 22:04, Vatofotsy went dark to the world for the first time in four years.



Ravo stood in the operations room and watched nine green lights go amber and then red, one after another, in eleven minutes.

The ninth was the Icelandic relay, and when it went he heard his own pulse in his ears.

“One Way?” he said.

One Way is intact, said his grandmother. The archive is published, mirrored, and beyond recall. The dead man’s timer is intact and will publish on schedule. What we have lost is the live channel. We can still receive. We cannot transmit.

“So we can hear the country,” said Fanja, “and the country cannot hear us.”

“Yes.”

“Which is what they want. Because now they can do anything up here for eleven days and the only version of it that exists is theirs.” She was already moving. “Mamy. Kitchen. Now.”



Here is the thing about Madagascar that four hundred million dollars of satellite architecture had made Ravo Andrianasolo forget, and that a seventy-one-year-old woman had never once, in her entire life, been in a position to forget.

Before the internet, there was the radio.

Before the radio, there was the road.

And before the road, and after it, and under it, and around it, for four hundred years, there was *fihavanana*: which is to say, a distributed, redundant, self-healing, unjammable network built out of cousins.

Mamy Solange Razafy had a Yaesu HF transceiver from 1994, a wire antenna between two mango trees, a school exercise book, and — this was the actual weapon, this was the thing that no directorate on earth could have modelled — the telephone numbers, marriage histories, tomb affiliations and personal debts of approximately eleven hundred families across four provinces.

She sat down at that radio at 22:40 on the second of May and she did not leave it, except to sleep four hours a night on a camp bed her nephew brought in, for fifteen days.



This is what the north did while it was switched off.

The pirogues. Sixty boats out of Ramena, forty out of Ankorikahely, more every day, sailing at four in the morning as they always had; except that now, in each boat, along with the nets, there was a plastic rice sack, and in the sack were memory cards and printed paper, and the boats met other boats at sea — they always had; the sea is a road — and by the sixth of May there was a relay running down the entire east coast, boat to boat, village to village, four hundred kilometres in eleven days, ending at a mobile tower in Sambava that the state had forgotten to switch off because it was registered to a vanilla cooperative.

The photocopiers. Four hundred thousand pages. The ninth column fitted, in nine-point type, on eleven sheets of A4. A church in Antsiranana ran a Xerox 2004 model until the drum failed, and then a school ran another, and then a hardware shop, and men on bicycles carried them into the hills, and old women who could not read carried them to men who could, and the reading-aloud began — in courtyards, in markets, outside churches after mass and outside the mosque after Friday prayers, in the enormous echoing shed of the Antsiranana fish market at four in the morning.

The FM. Eleven pirate transmitters, none of them more than a few watts, built out of kits by boys of Njiva's age, moved every night, running on car batteries, playing three things on a loop: the six-minute audio of two men laughing about the price of tin; a woman from Ramena reading the forty-one names slowly, with the pauses of somebody who is not a professional; and, between them, music.

The taxi-brousse. The mini-buses that are the actual circulatory system of the island, and whose drivers, as a class, have never in four hundred years liked a checkpoint. Two thousand vehicles. Nobody organised it. Nobody had to.

And the HF. Every night at 20:00, on 7.140 megahertz, a seventy-one-year-old woman's voice came up out of the static, and said, always the same way:

Good evening. This is Vatofofotsy. Everybody here is alive. I will now read the names of everybody here, so that their mothers can sleep.

And she read four hundred and eleven names, slowly, every night, for fifteen nights, and the reason she did it was not sentiment: it was that a name read on the radio at 20:00 is a person who cannot quietly stop existing at 20:30, and Mamy Solange, who had lived through 1972 and 1991 and 2002 and 2009, had understood this since she was eighteen years old.



The blackout lasted fifteen days and it produced, in the end, exactly one result, which was the opposite of the intended one.

It converted a scandal about a spreadsheet into an occupation.

Because a province that is switched off is a province that has been *told something*, and what four hundred thousand people in the north of Madagascar were told, unmistakably, by the darkness in their houses, was: *we are prepared to do this to you, in order to do something to them, that we do not want you to see.*

On the ninth of May, in Antsiranana, eleven thousand people walked from the fish market to the prefecture in silence, carrying photocopies over their heads instead of banners, and stood there for two hours, and went home.

On the eleventh, in Antananarivo, where the lights were still on, the university came out.

On the twelfth, the taxi-brousse drivers stopped, everywhere, all at once, for one day, which in Madagascar is roughly equivalent to stopping the blood.

On the thirteenth, the Federation of Vanilla Producers of the SAVA region — an organisation that had never in its life issued a political statement, that represented eighty per cent of the world's vanilla and roughly nine per cent of the country's foreign exchange, and whose members are, to a man, deeply conservative — published a communiqué of four sentences, the last of which read:

We are farmers and we do not concern ourselves with politics. But we have read the letters in the box, and we notice that they were stamped.

The Turning of the Bones

The dead are not gone. The dead are simply not in a hurry.

— Malagasy saying

In the second week of the blackout, in the highlands, it was the season for *famadihana*, and nobody in the government thought about that at all, which tells you everything.

The turning of the bones is not a funeral. A funeral is for grief and it happens once. *Famadihana* happens every five or seven years, in the dry cool season between July and September in the highlands, and it is a party: a brass band, a marquee, a great deal of rum, four hundred relatives who have travelled from everywhere, an ox killed, rice for the whole village. The tomb is opened. The ancestors are brought out into the sunlight, wrapped in fresh silk *lambamena*, carried on the shoulders of their descendants, danced with — actually danced with, held, spun, laughed with — and told, out loud, everything that has happened in the family since last time. Then they are put back, in new cloth, having been informed.

It is not morbid. It is the opposite of morbid. It is the single most concrete assertion any culture has ever made that the dead remain members of the family and are entitled to be kept up to date.

Now.

If you have been told, in a document, that your uncle who drowned in 2011 did not drown — if there is a photocopy in

your house with his name in a column headed *settlement* and a price beside it in a currency you use to buy rice — then the next time you open that tomb, you are not going to be able to look at him.

That was the thing the ninth floor never understood, and it is why they lost.

They thought they were fighting a news cycle.

They were fighting a debt to the dead.



On the tenth of May, in a village in the Vakinankaratra, a family opened a tomb.

They were not political people. The senior man present was a sixty-eight-year-old retired rural schoolteacher named Randriamampionona. The dead man being turned was his younger brother, who had been a magistrate's clerk in Antsirabe and who had died in 2014 of what the family had been told was a stroke, and who was number nineteen.

There was a brass band. There were four hundred people. There was an ox.

And when they had brought the body out into the light, and the women had begun the wrapping, the old schoolteacher climbed onto the low wall of the tomb with a photocopy in his hand — eleven sheets of A4, folded and refolded until the creases were soft as cloth — and he did what the head of a family does at *famadihana*, which is to tell the ancestor the news.

He said: *Brother. Since we last spoke, your daughter has married and has two sons, and the older one is called after you. The rice was poor in 2019 and good after. Our mother's tomb has been repaired. And, brother —*

And then he read entry nineteen aloud, over his brother's bones, in front of four hundred people, and gave the price.

There is a video. Of course there is a video; there were four hundred people and every one of them had a telephone. It is one minute and fifty-one seconds long, it is shaky, the sound is bad, the brass band can be heard giving up raggedly at the eleven-second mark as the musicians realise what is being said.

It went everywhere.

Not because it was dramatic. Because every single Malagasy who watched it understood, instantly and in their body, what had just happened: an ancestor had been *informed*. Formally. In the presence of witnesses. Under the correct ritual conditions.

Something had been placed on the account.



By the fifteenth of May there had been, by a count later made by two anthropologists at the University of Antananarivo, four hundred and eleven *famadihana* and memorial ceremonies at which a page of the ninth column was read aloud over a tomb, in seventeen of the country's twenty-two regions, including nine for people whose bodies had never been recovered and for whom the families opened the tomb anyway and read the entry to an empty shelf.

The government did not have a response to this. There is no response to this. You cannot issue a communiqué about it. You cannot arrest a brass band. Nirina Ravelojaona, who understood it better than any of his colleagues, sat in the blue-carpeted room on the fourteenth of May with the video playing on a laptop with the sound off, watching an old man on a tomb wall for the eleventh time, and said to a subordinate who repeated it under oath:

We can survive the mine. We can survive the rice. We could even have survived the ninth column, in a city, among educated people, with lawyers, over three years.

We cannot survive a country that has started telling its dead.



On the fifteenth of May the international undersea cable came back on line, because a consortium in Marseille had been served with a legal instrument by four hundred lawyers and because the insurance implications of the state of emergency had made a bank in Paris telephone a ministry in a tone of voice that ministries recognise.

At 18:11, nine green lights came back.

At 18:20, Vatofotsy resumed transmission, and the first thing it put out was not a statement.

It was one hour and eleven minutes of continuous, unedited, single-camera video of the kitchen at Vatofotsy: an old woman at a radio set, reading four hundred and eleven names.

It had, by midnight, eleven million views.

At 23:40 that night, in the blue-carpeted room, a man who had never in nineteen years signed anything containing a verb picked up a telephone and gave, for the first time in his life, a direct, unambiguous, verbal order to a general.

The transcript of that call is Exhibit 1 of the Commission.

It is four sentences long.

General. On the seventeenth, at first light, you will take the peninsula of Vatofotsy with everything you have. There will be no negotiation, no ultimatum and no press. Whatever happens up there, happens to foreign mercenaries who fired first.

And I want the balloon down before the sun.

PART THREE



THE RECKONING

The Sixteenth of May

On the eve, everyone becomes very calm and very practical. It is the most frightening thing I have ever seen in a group of human beings.

— Dr Lalao Ranaivo, deposition, p. 71

Hanta Ravelonarivo came up the road at four in the afternoon on the sixteenth of May in a taxi-brousse with a broken windscreen, sitting between a woman with a live chicken and a man carrying nineteen kilograms of dried fish, having travelled one thousand two hundred kilometres in four days on eleven separate vehicles because the airline had cancelled her ticket twice and the third time had cancelled her.

She got out at the first bridge with a canvas bag and no shoes worth the name and stood there while a young man with a rifle explained, apologetically, that he would have to search her bag.

“Search it,” she said.

He searched it. It contained: two notebooks, a charger, four pens, a toothbrush, a change of clothes, three hundred grams of coffee for a person she had not seen in eleven weeks, and a stack of photocopies eleven sheets thick, folded soft.

He gave her back the bag and did not know where to look.

“You’re Ravelonarivo,” he said.

“I am.”

“My mother reads you.”

“Tell your mother,” said Hanta, “that the roof at page four hundred and eleven is going to take another year, and she should stop writing to me about it, because I agree with her.”



Ravo met her on the terrace, and neither of them managed the thing they had rehearsed.

He said: “You should not be here.”

She said: “Do not start.”

Then she put down the bag and looked at him properly — at eleven weeks of it, at the twelve kilos, at the eyes — and said, in a completely different voice:

“Ravo. They let me go on the thirtieth. Nobody lets you go. You know that. Nobody lets a journalist go in the middle of a thing like this. I have been trying for two weeks to work out what I am for, and I worked it out at Ambondromamy at three in the morning.”

“What are you for?”

“I’m the witness they *want* here,” she said. “They released me and cancelled my flights and then made sure I could travel by road. They want a famous journalist inside that perimeter when it happens, because a famous journalist inside the perimeter makes it a *siege of a compound of foreigners and their collaborators* instead of a massacre of cooks. I am not here to be saved by you. I am here because I would rather be the witness on the inside than the story on the outside, and because if I am going to be used as a prop I would prefer to write my own captions.”

Ravo said nothing for a while. Out at sea, four kilometres, the pirogues were going out.

“Also,” said Hanta, “our daughter is on this rock, and I have not seen her since February, and if you think I was going to stay in Antananarivo you have understood nothing about me in twenty-four years.”



He had spent the day trying to send people away.

It had not gone well. It had, in fact, gone extremely badly, and Fanja had watched it with the particular satisfaction of an officer whose commander is being taught something she could not have taught him.

Two boats had gone out at noon: the *Vintsy* and the *Fanam-binana*, and between them they had capacity for one hundred and eleven people, and they had left with forty-one, of whom thirty-nine were children under fourteen and two were their grandmothers, and even that had taken Ravo, Mamy Solange, Doctor Ranaivo and three grandfathers four hours of argument.

Everyone else stayed.

The masons stayed. The cooks stayed. The schoolteacher stayed and taught, that morning, a normal lesson to nine children whose parents had refused the boat, about the water cycle. Bakoly Razanamalala, who had sold fried bread outside Arrachart aerodrome since 1989 and who had come up the road on the eleventh, stayed and made four hundred *mofo gasy* in the afternoon, because, as she explained to a camera, men who are frightened should have something in their hands.

At 17:00 Ravo stood on the crate in the magazine for the last time and made the shortest speech of the entire affair.

"They come at first light," he said. "The boats go again at nine tonight and at four in the morning, and there is room. That is all. That is everything I have to say. Thank you for staying. I am not able to say anything else."

He got down.

Mamy Solange got up, which nobody expected, and said, in Malagasy, from the floor, without moving to the crate:

"*Ny valiny dia efa nomena.*" The answer has already been given. "We have all been asked this question before, my children — in 1947, in 1971, in 1991, in 2009 — and every one of

those times the question was asked in the dark and answered alone, and the ones who answered it were never counted. Tonight we are being asked it with the lights on and four hundred people watching, and the whole island is holding the lamp.”

She sat down.

“So eat,” she said. “It’s romazava. There’s enough.”



They ate romazava, four hundred and eleven of them, in the old French magazine under the granite, at six in the evening on the sixteenth of May: beef and *brèdes mafana*, the greens that make your mouth tingle, and rice, and there was a great deal of noise, and at some point someone got a guitar and someone else got the accordion the old signaller had brought on his bicycle, and by nine o’clock there was, and this is documented on four separate cameras, dancing.

Fanja Rasoanaivo did not dance. She walked the wall.

She walked it three times between eight and midnight, which was twice more than necessary, and she stopped at every position and asked every person the same four questions, and the last question, always, was: *what is the thing you are most afraid you’ll get wrong?*

She wrote the answers in a notebook. It is in the archive of the Commission. It is, in its way, the most complete portrait of a defence that exists, and the last entry, at 23:51, in her handwriting, in French, is not about a position at all.

Number 41: R.A. Afraid he will be the only one left. Told him this is likely and is not a moral failure. He did not believe me. Note for tomorrow: if it goes badly, get him into the tunnel FIRST, whatever he says, even if I have to have him carried. The file is the point. Not him. He has forgotten this and I have not.



At 01:00 on the seventeenth, Njiva Andriamalala, nineteen years old, six feet of elbows, sat in a room in the rock with four screens and a rice-cooker and did the last thing on his list, which was to write a letter to his mother in Andavamamba and give it to Mamy Solange to keep.

It said, in full:

Mama. If you are reading this then I am dead and I am sorry, and also please tell Fara that the money is with Mamy and it is in your name and she cannot touch it. I want you to know that I was not frightened and that is a lie but it is a nice lie so please keep it. I built a wall out of four hundred small things and it held. The man here is a good man in the way that rich people are good, which is complicated. His daughter is very rude to me. I like it here. I am the best in the world at exactly one thing, Mama, and almost nobody gets to find out what their one thing is, so do not be too sad. Your son, Njiva.

He then went back to his screens and, at 01:40, began doing something with the swarm's cooperative logic that he had not told anybody about and that will be described in its place.

The Man in the Blue Room

A state is a story that a large number of people have agreed to tell each other every morning. It ends the way stories end: somebody stops.

— Antsiranana Commission, Vol. I, Introduction

While four hundred people ate romazava under a granite ceiling, the Republic came apart in a building on the Avenue de l'Indépendance, and it did so in the way these things always actually happen, which is not with a bang but with a series of telephone calls that nobody answers.



16:11. The Governor of the Central Bank telephones the Minister of Finance to report that the auction of ninety-day treasury bills has failed. Not undersubscribed: *failed*. Zero bids at any price. The Minister asks what that means in practice. The Governor, who is sixty-one and has been doing this since 1996 and whose voice on the recording is perfectly level, says: “It means that on the twenty-ninth of this month we do not pay salaries, Minister. Not the army’s. Not anybody’s.”

16:40. A Gulf sovereign fund with four hundred million dollars in a port concession serves formal notice of a claim under the bilateral investment treaty, citing “a fundamental breakdown in the rule of law.” It is the fourth such notice in nine days. The aggregate exposure passes two point one billion dol-

lars, which is roughly a quarter of what the entire country produces in a year.

17:15. The ambassador of a large European state, who has been requesting a meeting for eleven days, is finally granted one, arrives, declines coffee, remains standing, and reads out — reads out, from a paper, which in diplomacy is a form of violence — a two-paragraph statement noting that the Union’s rapid-response sanctions instrument permits designation within seventy-two hours, that a list has been prepared, that it contains fourteen names, and that his government “would find it regrettable if the events of the coming days made the list longer.”

He is asked whether the fourteen names might be shared.

He says: “Everyone in this building knows the fourteen names. They have known them since the second of April. They are in the file, at annexe six.”

18:00. The Minister of Strategic Resources does not attend the emergency cabinet. He is at Ivato airport, in the VIP salon, with his wife, two of his four children, eleven suitcases and a diplomatic passport, waiting for a private aircraft chartered from a company in Nairobi. The aircraft has been cleared to land, has landed, and is refuelling. It will not take off. At 19:40 the crew — three South Africans, whose employer has by then read the sanctions guidance and telephoned its insurer — will decline to accept the passengers and will depart empty, and a Minister of the Republic will stand at a window in the VIP salon in his shirtsleeves and watch an empty aeroplane leave without him, and will be photographed doing so by a baggage handler.

18:20. The Chief of the General Staff cannot be reached.

18:44. The Chief of the General Staff cannot be reached.

19:11. The Chief of the General Staff cannot be reached, and the Director of the Gendarmerie, when he is reached, says that his men are “engaged in public order duties in the capital” and cannot be released, which is a sentence that everybody

who hears it correctly translates into: *I have counted, and there are more of them than there are of you.*

20:00. In a bathroom on the eighth floor, a Secretary of State who has been in government for four months and who has, personally, done nothing worse than sign four documents he did not read, is sick into a basin for eleven minutes and then sits on the floor with his back against the wall and telephones his mother in Toliara and asks her, at forty-six years of age, whether he should come home.

21:30. The Palace issues a statement of eleven lines reaffirming its confidence in the institutions of the Republic. The phrase “the institutions of the Republic” appears three times, and the name of no living person appears at all, and every literate adult in the country understands the document perfectly.

22:15. The partner state that has, since the eleventh, been operating a leased armed reconnaissance aircraft from a detachment at a coastal aerodrome, on a commercial contract with the Ministry of Defence, informs the Malagasy liaison officer that its crews will fly “the sortie as contracted” on the seventeenth but that the contract will not be renewed and that the detachment will begin withdrawal on the eighteenth. In the internal message traffic of that partner state, subsequently leaked, the sortie is described as *the last one we owe them.*



And in the blue-carpeted room on the ninth floor, at 23:50, Nirina Ravelojaona sat alone with a cold cup of coffee, a laptop, and four hundred and eleven printed pages.

He was not sweating. He was not shouting. Men like Ravelojaona do not do those things; if they did them they would have been caught in 2004.

He was aligning the edges of the pages.

He had been aligning them for about forty minutes, in stacks of eleven, tapping each stack twice on the desk and setting it

down, and when his last remaining deputy came in at ten past midnight with a message he did not want, he found the Director-General of the Directorate of Territorial Coordination sitting in front of nineteen perfectly squared stacks of paper, and later described what he saw in a sentence that became, for a while, a phrase in the language:

He had made everything on the desk straight, and nothing else.

The message was this: two of the four helicopters had been declared unserviceable by their crews.

Ravelojaona said: "Unserviceable."

"Yes, sir."

"Both this evening."

"Yes, sir."

"Within an hour of each other."

"Yes, sir."

He nodded slowly, and squared another stack, and said something that his deputy repeated under oath and that the Commission printed as the epigraph to Volume III:

"Do you know what I have spent nineteen years building? Not money. Anybody can build money. I built a machine in which nobody had to decide anything. Everyone did their piece, and their piece was small, and nobody ever had to look at the whole. That is what a state *is*, when it works — a machine for distributing the deciding until nobody is doing it."

He set the stack down.

"That man has spent eleven weeks making everybody look at the whole thing at once, and now four hundred people have to decide, all on the same morning, individually, in daylight, on camera. And they will decide the way people do when they are being watched by their mothers."

He picked up his coffee, found it cold, and put it down again.

"Two helicopters," he said. "We shall see about the third."



At 00:31 he made three calls.

The first was to a general, and it lasted four minutes, and in it he authorised the use of the leased aircraft against “the technical installations” and confirmed, when asked directly — the general had learned, by then, to ask directly, and to record — that this included the aerostat winch, the radome, the power hall and the *residence*.

The second was to a lawyer in a European city, and it lasted eleven minutes, and it concerned the transfer of the beneficial interest in a Liechtenstein trust to a foundation controlled by his wife’s brother. It failed. The lawyer, who had read a newspaper, declined the instruction in a manner that Ravelojaona later described as “commercially unimaginative.”

The third was to his mother, who was eighty-four and lived in Fianarantsoa in a house he had bought her, and who had been telephoning him every day since the second of April and to whom he had not spoken once.

She answered on the fourth ring.

The transcript of that call does not exist, because it was made on his personal telephone and his personal telephone was never recovered.

But the Commission heard, from his mother, in a videotaped deposition taken in her house in Fianarantsoa when she was eighty-six, that her son had asked her whether she remembered the corridor at the hospital, and the nurse who said *monsieur, il n’y en a pas*, and she had said yes, and he had asked her whether she thought his father would have understood, and she had said:

Understood what, my son? Your father understood everything. He simply never agreed to it.

And then, she said, her son had said thank you, and had told her that he loved her, which he had not said since 1994, and had rung off.

At 03:30 he left the building on the Avenue de l'Indépendance and was driven east through the dark towards the coast, and he never entered that building again.

First Light

At 05:41 I was a soldier of the Republic. At 05:49 I was a man standing in a road in front of an old woman. Nobody trains you for the eight minutes.

— Sergeant-Chef H. Randriamalala, Vol. V

The seventeenth of May began at 04:14 with a sound that four hundred and eleven people had been told about and none of them had ever heard.

It was the Kite coming down.

Fanja had ordered it at 04:10, the moment the acoustic mesh confirmed the aircraft, because a tethered aerostat at three hundred metres is a magnificent eye and an unmissable target, and because Ravelojaona had said *I want the balloon down before the sun* on a line that Vatofotsy had been reading for nine days.

So they took it down themselves, in the dark, in four minutes, at a winch speed that made the cable sing — a rising, keening, enormous note off eleven kilometres of granite — and four hundred people underground heard it and knew exactly what it meant.

My child, said a dead woman from Ambanja, at 04:19. *It is a real aeroplane this time. It is coming from the west at four thousand metres and it is carrying something.*



The leased aircraft was a medium-altitude armed reconnaissance drone of a type that has, in the last decade, decided four wars and killed a great many people who were doing nothing at all. Twelve metres of wingspan, twenty-seven hours of endurance, four hardpoints. That morning it carried two guided munitions, and it was flown by two men in a container at an aerodrome three hundred and ninety kilometres away, on a satellite datalink, and their orders were to strike, in sequence, the winch house, the radome, and then to loiter.

The aircraft crossed the coast at 04:31.

At 04:34, at nineteen kilometres, its satellite navigation began, very slightly, to disagree with its inertial platform.

At 04:36 the Choir told it a story, and the story was the best thing Njiva Andriamalala ever built, and it went like this.

He did not spoof its position. Position spoofing is crude, and a modern airframe cross-checks position against its inertial unit and will, after a few seconds of disagreement, simply drop the satellite input and fly on inertia, and then you have an armed aircraft over your house that has stopped listening to you.

He spoofed the *ground*.

The synthetic-aperture radar and electro-optical sensors on that aircraft see the world and match it against a stored map, and that matching is how it knows where it is when everything else is lying, and Njiva had spent eleven weeks — since before the upload, since February, when Ravo had told him what was coming — building a false terrain: a rendering of the peninsula of Vatofotsy, in radar and infrared, correct in every particular, and displaced.

Not far. Two thousand two hundred metres to the north-east, over the open sea.

At 04:38 an aircraft that believed itself to be tracking a winch house with total confidence released a guided munition into four hundred metres of water, and then, thirty-one seconds later, released the second one, and two columns of

white water went up out of the black sea in front of the cliff, and the sound came across the rock like the end of the world, and in the magazine two hundred and eleven people who had been told the plan flinched anyway, because you cannot be told about that sound.

And then the aircraft, empty, obedient, and utterly certain of itself, was invited to land.



Njiva had built the strip in 2024, and Ravo had signed the invoice for it without asking, and Fanja had asked, and had been told: “Because one day one of them will be empty and lost and looking for somewhere to go, and I want somewhere to be here.”

At 04:51 a twelve-metre unmanned aircraft belonging to a foreign lessor, operated under a contract with the Ministry of Defence of the Republic of Madagascar, made a perfect autonomous landing on a nine-hundred-metre strip of graded laterite on the western slope of the Vatofotsy peninsula, believing itself to be at its home aerodrome three hundred and ninety kilometres away.

It rolled to a stop.

Four people ran out with a tarpaulin, a fire extinguisher and a camera.

Vatofotsy published, at 05:20, high-resolution photographs of the airframe, its serial number, its lessor’s plate, its maintenance placards, the ordnance racks with two empty stations, the datalink terminal, and — because Njiva had been recording the whole thing for eleven minutes — the last four seconds of downlinked video, which showed, quite clearly, a stretch of empty sea.

The caption, written by Hanta Ravelonarivo at 05:11 in a room in the rock with her shoes off, has been reprinted several thousand times:

At 04:38 this morning the Republic of Madagascar attempted to kill the man who published its ledger, with a rented aeroplane, using missiles that cost more than the school in Ramena. It missed by two kilometres and then it landed at his house. It is now his aeroplane. He is going to give it to the lawyers.



The rest of the seventeenth was not funny at all.

At 05:04 the third helicopter — the only one that flew — put twenty-four men of the intervention group onto the neck of the peninsula, eleven kilometres out, beyond the third bridge, which was the one thing Fanja had always said they would do if they had any sense, because the neck is scrub and rock and you cannot spoof a man's boots.

At 05:09 the column started up the road: eleven armoured vehicles, forty trucks, six hundred and eleven men of the first regiment, and — behind them, in nineteen civilian pickups, wearing no insignia — one hundred and forty foreign contractors assembled in eleven days by a broker in Dubai, who had been promised that the fighting would be over before they arrived.

At 05:14 Vatofotsy dropped the third bridge.

Four seconds, two keys, and eleven metres of concrete deck went into a ravine without hurting a soul, and six hundred men stopped, four kilometres from the wall, and had to walk.

At 05:31 the first shots of the day were fired, by the contractors, at the second bridge, at a range of nine hundred metres, at nothing.

At 05:40 they hit the fuel bunker.



It was a lucky round from a recoilless rifle and it should not have mattered, because the bunkers were cut into rock at elev-

en metres and the vents were baffled, and it did not penetrate anything.

What it did was open a fuel line in the transfer gallery, and set fire to it.

The transfer gallery ran for one hundred and forty metres between the bunkers and the power hall, and if it burned through to the hall then the four megawatts went, and if the four megawatts went then the batteries had nine hours, and if the batteries went then the Choir went, and if the Choir went then everything that Vatofotsy was — every lie it told, every wall it built out of small things — went with it.

The valves were manual. They were manual by design, because Ravo Andrianasolo did not trust a solenoid with the thing his whole world stood on. There were four of them and they were one hundred and eleven metres down the gallery, in the smoke.

Tsiky Rakotomavo, twenty-three, second diesel mechanic, who had answered nine questions on a road four times a month to hear his brother's voice for eleven seconds, was standing at the gallery door with a wet cloth over his face before anyone had given an order.

Somebody grabbed his shoulder. He shook it off.

He said — and there were four people in that corridor and all four of them say he said it in exactly these words, in Malagasy, without any particular drama, the way you would say it about a job —

“Fa izaho no mahalala ny valve.”

I'm the one who knows the valves.

He closed all four.

He got back to within nineteen metres of the door, and they found him there, and Lalao Ranaivo worked on him for six hours in a granite room and could not do it, and at 12:40 on the seventeenth of May the boy who had betrayed Vatofotsy died in it, having saved it, with his brother alive and free and

eleven hundred kilometres away, watching a livestream in a room full of strangers who did not yet know whose brother he was.

His name is fourth on the memorial because the memorial is in the order they fell.

The Line

Whose son are you?

— Question put by an unidentified woman, Ramena beach, 16 April, and again, by approximately four hundred people, on 17 May

At 06:40 the column reached the second bridge, and at 06:41 Fanja Rasoanaivo, standing at the north wall with a radio in her left hand, said the sentence that everybody at Vatofotsy had been dreading for eleven weeks:

“They’re not stopping.”

They were not stopping. Six hundred men were coming up a road on foot, in the open, in daylight, in the certain knowledge that they were under the guns of a fortified position, and there is only one reason a competent force does that, and the reason is that they have been told there will be no consequences because there will be no witnesses.

Fanja had eleven remote weapon stations, four hundred mosquitoes, three anti-materiel rifles, sixty-one professionals and a naval gun.

She could have killed two hundred human beings in ninety seconds. Every officer who has studied the ground agrees on this. Two hundred, in ninety seconds, mostly conscripts, most of them under twenty-four, from Sambava and Ambatondrazaka and Toliara and Diego, whose mothers were at that moment watching a livestream.

At 06:44 she gave the order that is carved, in Malagasy and French, on the lintel of the school that stands there now.

“*Tsy mitifitra isika.*” We do not shoot.

“Colonel—”

“We do not shoot. Nets on the drones. Smoke on the road at four hundred metres, thick, keep it walking backwards. Everybody behind stone. Nobody fires unless they are inside the wire, and if they get inside the wire you fire low and you fire to stop, and you will answer to me personally for every round.” She turned. “And get me the loudhailer, and get me Mamy, and get me the radio, and somebody tell Njiva to put every camera we own on the road *right now.*”



What happened between 06:50 and 07:40 on the seventeenth of May is the most thoroughly documented hour in the history of the Republic. There are one hundred and ninety-one separate video sources. Nine of them are the state’s own.

At 06:50 Vatofotsy began broadcasting the road.

Eleven camera angles, no commentary, live, with a caption bar that read, in Malagasy and French and English, and updated every thirty seconds:

NOBODY AT VATOFOTSY HAS FIRED A SHOT TODAY. 04:38 — TWO MISSILES. 05:31 — SMALL ARMS. 05:40 — FUEL BUNKER, ONE OF OURS IS DYING. WE HAVE NOT FIRED. WE WILL NOT FIRE FIRST. THERE ARE 370 PEOPLE HERE. 61 ARE ARMED. THE REST ARE COOKS, MASONS, NURSES, FISHERMEN, A TEACHER, NINE CHILDREN WHOSE PARENTS REFUSED THE BOAT.

At 06:58, in the village of Ramena, eleven kilometres down that road, four hundred people began to walk.

Nobody organised it. This has been investigated exhaustively — by the Commission, by two universities, by a foreign intelligence service that could not believe it — and the answer is always the same, and the answer is that in a village of four hundred houses where everybody is related to everybody, a thing

does not need to be organised: an old woman puts on her *lamba* and stands in the road, and her neighbour sees her through the window, and then it has already happened.

They walked up the road towards six hundred soldiers.

They were, in the count made afterwards from the footage: four hundred and eleven people at the start, one thousand one hundred by the fourth kilometre, and something over three thousand by nine o'clock, because the taxi-brousse drivers of Antsiranana had heard on the FM at 07:00 and had come, all of them, in convoy, empty, and had put them on the road for nothing.

They carried nothing. That was the discipline of it, and it was absolute, and it was Bakoly Razanamalala's idea, shouted at the third house: *no sticks, no stones, nothing in the hands*.

They carried nothing in their hands, and they walked into the space between an army and a wall, and they filled it.



Sergeant-Chef Herizo Randriamalala, aged thirty-one, of Sambava, who had put his helicopter down on a beach on the sixteenth of April and had been given coffee by an old woman, was in the third rank of the leading company on the road at 07:11 when the front rank stopped.

His account, given to the Commission and never once varied:

We stopped because we could not walk forward. That is all. There was no order to stop. There was no order not to stop. The road was full of people and we stopped because you cannot walk into people, and then we stood there for I think six or seven minutes, and nobody said anything, and I could hear the sea.

Then an old woman came out of the crowd and came to the front rank, and she did not shout, and she went along the rank asking each man the same question, and she got to me, and she took my face like this, in both hands, and I want to say to the

Commission that I had met this woman before, on the beach, and she knew me, and she said:

“Whose son are you?”

And I said, “Randriamalala, madame. From Sambava. You gave me coffee.”

And she said: “Then what are you doing on this road, my child?”

And I could not answer her. That is my testimony. I could not answer her.

At 07:19 Sergeant-Chef Randriamalala took his rifle off his shoulder, knelt down, and laid it on the road, muzzle towards the sea, and stood up again with his hands empty.

By 07:26 the entire leading company had done it.

By 07:40, four hundred and eleven weapons were lying on eleven kilometres of laterite road in the sun, and six hundred men were standing among three thousand civilians, and somebody’s mother was crying, and somebody had started, absurdly, to hand out fried bread.



And that is when the contractors opened fire.

They were nineteen kilometres from anything that could arrest them, they had not been paid, their broker had stopped answering at 05:00, they had watched an army lay down its weapons in front of a crowd, and one hundred and forty men who did not speak the language and had no country in this and no way home had, in that moment, exactly one asset: the belief that they were still the most dangerous thing on the road.

They fired over the crowd first, to move it.

The crowd did not move. This has been analysed too. It did not move because there were three thousand people packed into four hundred metres of road with a cliff on one side and a ravine on the other and there was, physically, nowhere to move to; and because the front of it was old women; and because —

a foreign correspondent wrote, and it is as good an explanation as anybody has — *by then everybody in that road understood that they were the story, and that a story that runs away stops being one.*

The second burst was not over the crowd.

A woman named Vololona Rasoanantenaina, aged fifty-nine, a fish trader from Ramena, mother of six, grandmother of eleven, was hit in the stomach at 07:44 and fell down in the road, and the people around her went down with her, and eleven of them dragged her towards the ditch, and she began to die in the open, in the sun, four hundred metres from the wall, in the field of fire of one hundred and forty professionals.

At 07:46 Colonel Fanja Rasoanaivo came out of the gate on foot.



She did not run. Everybody who has watched the footage says the same thing: she did not run, at any point, and the footage is eleven minutes long.

She had taken off her plate carrier. She had taken off her helmet. She had a white *lamba* — Mamy Solange's, taken off the old woman's shoulders at the gate without a word — held up in her right hand, the hand with two fingers missing, and she walked down the road with a stretcher in her left and a medic named Nivo Rakotonirina, aged twenty-six, walking beside her, and behind them, without being ordered, nineteen people from the village.

She walked four hundred metres in the open.

She got to Vololona Rasoanantenaina at 07:51 and knelt down in the road, and the shooting stopped — actually stopped, for ninety seconds, because even among one hundred and forty men who had run out of country, there were not many prepared to be the man who did it — and she got the woman onto the stretcher and stood up.

At 07:53 a single shot was fired from a position on the high ground above the second bridge, at a range of six hundred and eleven metres, by a person who has never been identified and who was not, forensic examination established, using ammunition of Malagasy service issue.

It struck Colonel Fanja Rasoanaivo below the left shoulder blade.

She fell across the stretcher. Nivo Rakotonirina and three fishermen from Ramena carried both women up the road together, and it took them nine minutes, and nobody fired at them, and the entire island watched it happen on eleven camera angles in real time.

Vololona Rasoanantenaina lived. She has since been elected to something.

Fanja Rasoanaivo, of Ambanja, of the 2nd Foreign Parachute Regiment, of Vatofotsy, mother of a medical student in Bordeaux, aged fifty-one, was pronounced dead in a granite room at 08:11 on the seventeenth of May.

Her last recorded words, on Nivo's body camera, at 07:52, one second before the shot, are not about any of this. She is looking at the wounded woman's face and she is saying, in Malagasy, in the flat, bored, competent voice of every medic in every war:

"Stay with me, my sister. You're too heavy to carry twice."



The soldiers went up the road.

That is the only way to describe what happened between 08:00 and 08:40, and there is no military vocabulary for it, and the Commission's account of it is one sentence long because the Commission's chairman decided, correctly, that anything else would be a diminishment:

At approximately 0800, the men of the first regiment, having disarmed themselves, advanced up the road in company with the

civilian crowd and, upon reaching the positions occupied by the foreign personnel, took those persons into custody by hand.

By hand.

Six hundred unarmed Malagasy soldiers and three thousand villagers walked up a road into one hundred and forty armed foreign contractors and took their weapons off them, one at a time, without firing a shot, over forty minutes, and the reason this worked — the actual, unromantic, mechanical reason — is the reason that Iliya Marchev had put in his six-minute briefing on the fifteenth of April and that nobody had listened to:

It is a video of your soldiers shooting a schoolteacher.

Nobody wants to be in that video. Not even men who have run out of country.

Eleven of the contractors fought. Four of them are dead. Two Malagasy soldiers and one villager, a mason named Fetra Andrianjafy, died in those forty minutes, and their names are second, third and sixth on the memorial, and by nine o'clock on the seventeenth of May the road was full of men sitting on their heels in the sun under the eyes of women in *lambas*, waiting for the gendarmerie to come and formally arrest them, which took, in the end, until Tuesday.

Forty-One Names

We had prepared for every scenario except the one where he was allowed to finish speaking.

— Antsiranana Commission, Vol. III, para. 209

At 18:00 on the seventeenth of May, with four dead in the infirmary and a road full of prisoners and a country that had not slept, Ravo Andrianasolo did the thing the entire fortress had been built to make possible.

He gave a *kabary*.

Not a speech. It matters that this is understood. *Kabary* is the formal oratory of the Malagasy highlands, and it is an art with rules, and the rules are not decoration: you begin by asking pardon of the ancestors and of your elders and of the assembly for daring to speak at all; you place yourself beneath everyone present; you do not come to the matter directly, but circle it, with proverbs, until it can be borne; and you speak on behalf of the family, never on behalf of yourself.

It is, in other words, precisely the opposite of everything the man had done for eleven weeks.

He wore no headset. He stood in the magazine, on the floor and not on the crate, with four hundred people behind him and one camera in front of him and Mamy Solange sitting on a stool at his right hand where an elder sits, and he was, by the account of everybody present, extremely bad at it for the first ninety seconds, and then not bad at all.

Tompokolahy sy tompokovavy, he began. Ladies and gentlemen. I beg the pardon of the ancestors, who are listening. I beg the pardon of the elders present, who are older than me and know more than me. I beg the pardon of the dead of today, who cannot object.

I am not a wise man. I am a man who was good at machines and became rich, which is a kind of luck that people mistake for a kind of virtue.

They say: the fingernail is small, but it removes the thorn.

They say: a person is not made by their body but by their spirit — ny fanahy no olona.

And they say — my grandmother said, and I did not understand her for thirty years — that a debt does not rot.

Eleven weeks ago I published a document. Today the state sent an aeroplane, and six hundred sons of this country, and one hundred and forty men from other countries who were paid in dollars, to prevent a document from continuing to be read. Four people who were in my care have died. A woman from Ramena was shot in the stomach in the road, and an officer who was the finest human being I have ever employed was killed carrying her, and a boy of twenty-three who had done us great harm walked into a fire and closed four valves and died of it.

So. Enough of me. I have spoken too long already and I ask pardon for it.

The document is a list. Lists are cold. I have decided that this one will not stay cold.

He stepped back.



What followed lasted one hour and fifty-one minutes and was broadcast live on eleven mirrors, on FM through four hundred pirate transmitters, on the national radio of two neighbouring countries, on HF at 7.140 megahertz by an old woman, and — from 18:40, when the technicians in the building simply

stopped obeying instructions — on the state television of the Republic of Madagascar.

Forty-one people came, one at a time, and stood in front of one camera in a granite room, and read one entry.

They were: a widow of eighty-one. A son. Four daughters. A brother who had come one thousand two hundred kilometres by taxi-brousse in four days. A nun from Betroka who read the entry of the nun from Betroka, because the dead woman had had no family and her order had sent the youngest of them. A twenty-six-year-old blogger's mother, who could not finish, and stood there, and was not hurried, and finished. A hydrologist's widower. Fetra Rakotomavo, aged nineteen, released without shoes on the twenty-eighth of April, who read nothing at all but stood in front of the camera for eleven seconds holding a photograph of his brother, who had been dead for six hours.

And forty-first, last, because Mamy Solange had arranged the order and had refused to discuss it:

A man of forty-four in a dirty shirt, who had not slept in two days, who put a folded photograph on the table in front of him and did not look at the camera at all.

Entry seven, he read. Twelfth of March, two thousand and nine. Subject: Rakotobe, Andriamahefa Jean. Function: Deputy Controller of Manifests, Port of Toamasina, Quay Four. Category: obstruction, persistent. Method: road. Location: RN2, kilometre one hundred and eighty-six, descent of the Mandraka. Settlement: eleven million ariary. Authorising initial: N.R. Status: closed.

Then he looked up.

He was my father, he said. He was fifty-one. He had a green Renault 4 and he could not sing. He signed for containers for nineteen years and for six years he would not sign for the ones that were not there, and they wrote it down, and they wrote down what it cost, and they filed my mother's letters in a box.

I want to say the last part in Malagasy because he did not like French.

And he said it in Malagasy, and it is eleven words long, and it is on the lintel of the school:

“Dada, tsy very ny anaranao. Voasoratra izy, ary novakiana mafy.”

Father — your name is not lost. It was written down, and it has been read aloud.



The Republic of Madagascar effectively ceased to function as a government at some point during those one hundred and eleven minutes, and the exact moment is a matter of scholarly dispute.

Some say 19:04, when the state broadcaster’s technicians put the feed to air.

Some say 19:31, when the Chief of the General Staff, who had been unreachable for twenty-three hours, appeared on that same feed, in uniform, alone, and read a four-sentence statement placing the armed forces “at the disposal of the institutions and of the population” and announcing that no unit would be deployed against civilians, which was, everybody understood, not a coup but the opposite of one: it was a man refusing to be given orders.

Some say 20:00, when the *fokontany* — the neighbourhood assemblies, the smallest and oldest unit of Malagasy self-government, older than the Republic, older than the French, older than the kingdom — began, in Antananarivo and Toamasina and Mahajanga and Fianarantsoa and Toliara and Antsiranana, and then in villages nobody in the capital could find on a map, to meet, at night, spontaneously, in their hundreds, and to do the thing that *fokontany* do, which is to sit in a circle and talk until everybody has spoken.

But the anthropologists — and on this the two who wrote the standard account are firm — say it was earlier, and quieter, and that it happened in about four hundred thousand houses at

once, at some point during the forty-one readings, and that it was the moment when the people of a country stopped experiencing a scandal and started experiencing a *bereavement*, which is a thing that has to be completed, by rules, with the family present, and which no communiqué has ever once in human history been able to interrupt.

Ny Fanahy no Olona

The tribunal will note that the accused was arrested by a customs officer.

— Antsiranana Commission, Vol. VII, closing summary

Nirina Ravelojaona was arrested at 04:41 on the nineteenth of May at the Port of Toamasina, at Quay Four, by a customs officer of twenty-four named Onja Ramanantsoa, who had been in the job for eleven months.

There is no dramatic version of this. It is on a fixed camera and it lasts four minutes.

A grey Prado comes to the vehicle barrier. A man in the back seat has a diplomatic passport, a bag, and a letter on ministry paper authorising his embarkation aboard a Panamanian-flagged bulk carrier that has been waiting at anchor since Saturday. The letter is signed by a Secretary of State who by that hour had been in the custody of the gendarmerie for nineteen hours, which the man in the car does not know.

The young customs officer reads the letter. He goes back into his booth. He is there for two minutes and eleven seconds, and what he is doing — he told the Commission this, and was embarrassed about it — is looking up the ninth column on his telephone, because he wants to be certain about the initials.

Then he comes back out, and hands the letter through the window, and says the sentence that is, today, printed on a poster that hangs in the customs school:

“Tsy hanao sonia aho, tompoko.”

I will not sign, sir.

And Nirina Ravelojaona — fifty-eight years old, first in his lycée, second in his province, the cleverest man in the Republic, who had spent nineteen years building a machine in which nobody had to decide anything — sat in the back of a car at Quay Four in the Port of Toamasina, forty metres from the office where a Deputy Controller of Manifests had spent six years refusing to sign for containers that were not there, and looked at a boy of twenty-four, and did not say anything at all.

He was still sitting there, with the door open, when the gendarmerie arrived eleven minutes later.



The rest is procedure, and procedure is what a country gets instead of catharsis.

The Antsiranana Commission sat for nineteen months. Its seven volumes run to four thousand one hundred pages and were published, in Malagasy and French, with a print run that sold out in two days and a digital version mirrored, on the first morning, forty-one thousand times, by a script that a nineteen-year-old had written for something else entirely.

Eleven former ministers, three generals, four judges, nineteen officials and a Franco-Mauritian lawyer named Xavier Delcroix-Auber were charged. Nine were convicted at home. Four were convicted abroad, under universal jurisdiction, in a European city, in a courtroom with simultaneous translation into Malagasy that the court had to source from a language school because there had never been a need for it before.

Cintra Resources Holdings SA was wound up. The concession was voided by a tribunal that took two years to agree that a contract procured by the payment of four hundred and six million dollars to a trust benefiting the officials who signed it is, in fact, void — a proposition that cost the Republic nineteen

million dollars in legal fees to establish and which every fisherman in Ramena could have stated for free in one sentence.

The eleven trawlers left the Mozambique Channel. Nine of them are working somewhere else now, off another coast, in another country's water, under another licence, because the ocean is large and the file was only about Madagascar.

Serge Cazenave served four years and now farms, badly, near Perpignan, and gave the Commission one hundred and eleven hours of testimony that was worth every day of the sentence reduction he did not ask for.

Iliya Marchev was never charged with anything, because he had declined, and gave a single interview in which he said: *I want to be extremely clear that I did not refuse for moral reasons. I refused because the arithmetic was bad. The moral reasons were available to everybody. They were free. Nobody picked them up.*

Nirina Ravelojaona is serving thirty-one years. He has not spoken publicly since the trial. He is said to be a model prisoner, courteous with the staff, and to have organised a literacy class. His mother died in Fianarantsoa in the third year without seeing him, and left him, in a will of four lines, her husband's letters from former students, of which there are four hundred and eleven.



Vatofotsy is a school.

Not a metaphorical one. Ravo Andrianasolo transferred the entire peninsula — four hundred and ten hectares, the residence, the tunnels, the desalination plant, the power station, the strip and the blue-eyed geckos — to a Malagasy foundation in the second year, along with an endowment of eight hundred million dollars, which is to say most of what was left after four hundred lawyers, and the foundation runs a lycée and a technical institute for nine hundred pupils from the four northern districts, boarding, free, with an entrance examination that is

famously and deliberately impossible to bribe your way through, because the marking is done in Nairobi by people who do not know the candidates' names.

The old magazine is the dining hall. Four hundred and eleven children eat under that granite ceiling twice a day and complain about the food.

The gun is still in the emplacement, under its canvas, maintained by an armourer from Brittany who comes twice a year and is now eighty-one. It has been fired four times since: once a year, on the seventeenth of May, at eleven minutes past eight in the morning, with a blank charge, and the whole school stands.

The 1942 tunnels are the physics laboratories, which nobody planned and everybody agrees is funny.

The Kite still flies. There was a considerable argument about the Kite, and Njiva Andriamalala won it, on the grounds that a school on a headland ought to be able to see the weather coming, and that children like it, and that in nineteen villages along that coast people still, out of an eleven-week habit they cannot break, look up to check that it is there.



Njiva runs a company in Antananarivo with two hundred employees, half of them from Andavamamba, and will not sell it, and has turned down, at last count, four acquisition offers, the largest of them from a defence contractor whose letter he framed and hung in the toilet.

Hanta Ravelonarivo edits the newspaper that came out of the consortium. It is small and solvent and nobody has ever bought it. She has been sued eleven times and has lost twice, and says the two losses were fair. She and Ravo did not remarry, which surprised everybody who did not know them and nobody who did.

Miora Andrianasolo is twenty-six. She did not become an engineer and she did not become a journalist. She is a hydrologist, which is a thing that seems eccentric until you look at the list and find, at entry one, a hydrologist from Antsirabe who published water-table data, and then it is not eccentric at all.

Mamy Solange Razafy lived to be eighty-six and died in her own bed at Vatofotsy in the room over the kitchen, having been read to, in her last week, by four hundred children in rotation, eleven minutes each, which she had organised herself and about which she was extremely bossy. She is buried on the hillside above Ramena in the family tomb, with the others, and she will be turned in the proper season, and told the news.

And Kofi Adjei went home in November of the following year, wrapped in silk, on an aeroplane, exactly as an old woman had promised his wife on a livestream at four in the morning.



Ravo Andrianasolo is fifty-one now — the age his father was — and lives in four rooms in the old signal station and teaches, badly, one class a week: applied mathematics to seventeen-year-olds, most of whom think he is a slightly embarrassing old man who used to be famous, which is exactly the arrangement he has requested.

He has been asked, several hundred times, the question that everybody wants answered, which is: *was it worth it?* And he has refused to answer it several hundred times, because he says the question is dishonest — that a man who has four dead people in his ledger does not get to run the arithmetic on them, that arithmetic of that kind is exactly what the ninth column was, and that the day he starts weighing Fanja Rasoanaivo against a tribunal is the day he becomes a very small version of Nirina Ravelojaona.

What he says instead, when he cannot avoid it, is this, and he says it in Malagasy even to foreigners, and lets somebody translate:

I did not save anybody. I bought time. That is the only thing that money has ever actually purchased and everything else it appears to purchase is a story about time.

I bought eleven weeks in which a document could not be turned into a rumour. Three hundred and seventy people bought the rest of it, and four of them paid for it with the whole thing, and the country did the part that mattered, which was not the shooting — there was almost no shooting — but the fact that on the seventeenth of May, four thousand people walked up a road and made themselves the only thing that a rifle cannot be pointed at, which is a witness.

Ny fanahy no olona. It is the spirit that makes the person.

They wrote our dead into a spreadsheet in a column headed settlement, and they thought that was the end of it, and it was not the end of it, because in this country the dead are members of the family and members of the family get told the news.

We told them. That is all we did. We told them.

Vintsy

There is a bird here called the *vintsy*, a Malagasy kingfisher, the size of your fist, orange and lapis, absurd, which sits on a wire above the water at Ramena and does nothing at all for forty minutes and then, without warning, is somewhere else entirely with a fish.

In the third year, a boy of eleven from Andavamamba, in Antananarivo, in a house where the water comes up through the floor twice a year, sat on a bucket with a cracked telephone that had been his aunt's, on a network that cost him two hundred ariary he had earned carrying water, and watched, for the first time, a video that his mother had told him about and that he had never seen.

It is one minute and fifty-one seconds long. The sound is bad. There is a brass band that gives up raggedly at the eleven-second mark.

An old man is standing on the wall of a tomb in the highlands with eleven sheets of paper in his hand, folded soft, and he is telling his brother the news.

The boy watched it four times.

Then he went and found his mother, who was standing in the doorway because it was the coolest place in the house, and he asked her the question that four hundred thousand Malagasy children asked their mothers in that decade and that no government in the history of this island has ever survived being asked twice.

He said: *Mama. Whose son am I?*

Author's Note

This is a novel. It is fiction, and it should be read as fiction.

The Republic of Madagascar is a real country with a real and living democracy, real institutions, real journalists, real magistrates, real customs officers and real civil servants, and every character in this book — Ravo Andrianasolo, Nirina Ravelojaona, Fanja Rasoanaivo, Solange Razafy, Hanta Ravelonarivo, the ministers, the generals, the Directorate of Territorial Coordination itself — is invented. So are Cintra Resources, the Karakurt Group, Vatofofotsy, Cyclone Vony, the Antsiranana Commission, the ninth column and every one of its forty-one entries. No serving or former official of Madagascar, and no living person anywhere, is depicted or intended here, and nothing in these pages should be read as an allegation against any real individual, company or institution.

What is real is the setting, and the setting was chosen with affection rather than accusation: the great bay in the north that navies have wanted for four hundred years; the ylang-ylang of Ambanja; the vanilla of the SAVA; the pirogues that go out at two in the morning; the taxi-brousse that will get you anywhere on this island eventually; the *fokontany*; the *kabary*; and above all *famadihana*, the turning of the bones, and *fihavanana*, which is the hardest word in the book to translate and the only one that really matters. Any errors in the rendering of those things are the author's, and are regretted.

The technology is deliberately impressionistic. Where this book describes how something is defended or defeated, it has been written to be read, not followed; the details that would matter have been changed, removed, or invented. This is a story about what a fortress cannot do.

Because that, in the end, is what it is about. The man in this book buys the most formidable private defence in the southern hemisphere and it wins him precisely one thing: eleven weeks in which he cannot be silenced, disappeared, or converted into a rumour. Everything that actually changes is done by people with nothing in their hands — an old woman at a radio, a boy with a photocopier, a customs officer of twenty-four who declines to sign, four hundred villagers who walk up a road.

Fortresses buy time. Only people spend it.

A Note on the Malagasy

fiavanana — kinship, and the web of obligation between kin; the central social value of Malagasy life, closer to “the bonds that make us mutually responsible” than to any English word.

razana — the ancestors, understood as present members of the family.

famadihana — “the turning of the bones”: the periodic ceremony in which ancestors are taken from the tomb, rewrapped in fresh silk, danced with, and told the family news.

lambarena — the silk shroud used in *famadihana*. *lamba* — the cloth worn over the shoulders.

tsiny — the blame or moral debt incurred towards the ancestors and the community; not guilt, which is private, but liability, which is not.

fady — taboo; a prohibition whose violation contaminates.

kabary — the formal oratory of the highlands, governed by rules of humility, indirection and proverb.

hainteny — traditional Malagasy poetry.

fokontany — the smallest unit of local administration and assembly; in practice, the neighbourhood meeting.

tanindrazana — the land of the ancestors; homeland.

mora mora — “slowly, slowly”; the national answer to hurry.

vazaha — foreigner, usually European.

havana — kin, relative.

romazava — the national dish: beef with *brèdes*, including *brèdes mafana*, which numbs the mouth.

mofo gasy — “Malagasy bread”: small rice-flour cakes eaten at breakfast from a street stall, with coffee.

taxi-brousse — the shared long-distance minibus; the circulatory system of the island.

vintsy — the Malagasy kingfisher.

moka — mosquito.

ariary — the currency.

Ny fanahy no olona — “It is the spirit that makes the person.”

Tsy hanao sonia aho, tompoko — “I will not sign, sir.”